

Is Bezos trying
to defang
The Post?

BEST AMERICAN
COLUMNISTS P14



The scandal
engulfing
Norway's royals

BEST INTERNATIONAL
ARTICLES P17



Dazzling
interpretation or
empty spectacle?

FILM P27



THE WEEK

14 FEBRUARY 2026 | ISSUE 1579

THE BEST OF THE BRITISH AND INTERNATIONAL MEDIA

Starmer clings on But is he fatally weakened?

Page 2



Keir Starmer: a Prime Minister in peril

For a moment this week, No. 10 thought it was all over, said Patrick Maguire in *The Times*. The wave of outrage over the latest revelations about Peter Mandelson's links to the sex offender Jeffrey Epstein seemed poised to sweep Keir Starmer from office. The PM's chief of staff, Morgan McSweeney, had resigned on Sunday, saying he took full responsibility for advising Starmer to appoint Mandelson as ambassador to the US. The next morning, the PM's communications director, Tim Allan, had stood down as well. Hours later, Anas Sarwar, Labour's leader in Scotland, had become the party's first senior figure publicly to call for Starmer to step aside. It looked like the prelude to a putsch. "Yet to widespread relief, confusion and morbid amusement" among Starmer's team, nobody rallied behind Sarwar. Instead, every Cabinet member issued a message of support for the PM. As Energy Secretary Ed Miliband put it on Tuesday, Labour had "looked over the precipice" and decided to stick with Starmer.



The PM: will the knives come out in May?

"Keir's not driving the train. He thinks he's driving the train, but we've sat him at the front of the DLR." The loss of McSweeney will hurt, agreed Mary Harrington on *UnHerd*. He excelled at the dark arts needed to "sustain an illusion of internal coherence within this incoherent and fissiparous party", and was a useful restraining influence against its "madder" left-wing instincts.

That's one way of looking at it, said Owen Jones in *The Guardian*. The other is that McSweeney was the purveyor of a cynical, vacuous form of reheated Blairism that has led Starmer's Government into the ditch, just as the Left warned it would. If Labour had any sense, it would "adopt a programme of progressive taxation to fund investment in broken services and struggling communities ... end the failed privatisation experiment and deliver

a mass public house-building programme". Whether the PM is replaced or not, the "only direction of travel for the Labour leadership is leftwards", said Mark Wallace in *The i Paper*. Starmer has exhausted the party's willingness to compromise on its beliefs. This crisis marks the final victory of the more ideological, Ed Miliband version of Labour, agreed Daniel Finkelstein in *The Times*. Labour is, at heart, a "soft-left party" and is happier

governing as such. But this is not the agenda it was elected on.

For now, perhaps, said the *FT*. But make no mistake: this is only a stay of execution. Starmer has made too many misjudgements in office. He has lost all authority in the party and is no longer in control of events. It's "barely conceivable" that he could lead

"McSweeney wasn't just any old aide; he was the architect of 'the entire Starmer project'"

Labour into the next election. The PM's potential challengers have their own reasons for holding fire for now, said Trevor Phillips in *The Times*. Angela Rayner is waiting to resolve her row with the tax authorities; Wes Streeting needs to shake off the taint of his association with Mandelson; Andy Burnham needs to get back into the Commons. It's in nobody's interest in any case to take over the leadership before May's local elections, which look set to be a "bloodbath" for Labour, said Sonia Sodha in *The Independent*. Better to leave Starmer to "take the rap" for that. Labour's factions could also do with more time to develop their thinking about where to take the party. "The phoney war may continue for some time yet."

The question now, said Tom Harwood in *The Critic*, is how Starmer will cope without his right-hand man. McSweeney wasn't just any old aide; he was the architect of "the entire Starmer project". In *Get In*, the behind-the-scenes account of Labour's return to power, one of McSweeney's friends notoriously cited the driverless Docklands Light Railway:

Voters wouldn't take kindly to "an unelected soft-left takeover", said Josh Glancy in *The Sunday Times*. And while other candidates might prove more politically adept than Starmer, they'd be constrained by the same daunting problems: "soaring welfare costs, small boats ... a stagnant economy, the madness of Trump ... a creaking NHS, jittery bond markets". Labour would be crazy to oust Starmer now, less than halfway through its parliamentary term, said Stephen Daisley in *The Spectator*. Its leaders are making "the Tory mistake of prizing their frustrations (and ambitions) over the public's greatest desire: a quiet life". We've had too much of this "self-indulgent" nonsense in recent years, agreed Ambrose Evans-Pritchard in *The Daily Telegraph*. Restless MPs have conspired with special advisers and "the media wolf pack of the Lobby" to hound a series of leaders out of power. It's leaving the country increasingly ungovernable, harming our economic recovery and doing enormous damage to Britain's reputation.

It wasn't all bad

The "Tudor Heart", a gold pendant linked to Henry VIII's marriage to Catherine of Aragon, has been secured for the nation thanks to a fundraising campaign led by the British Museum. It raised the £3.5m required to acquire the 24-carat piece, which was found by a detectorist in a field in Warwickshire in 2019. The pendant features the Tudor rose and Catherine's pomegranate symbol, as well as a banner that reads "tousiors" – old French for "always".

A toddler has won two Guinness World Records by becoming the youngest person to perform a pair of snooker trick shots. Despite being barely tall enough to reach the table, Jude Owens, from Manchester, pulled off a snooker double pot at two years and 261 days old; a fortnight later, he executed a pool bank shot. His father, Luke Owens, said he'd introduced Jude to snooker at home, and that the boy had taken to it like a duck to water once he'd learnt to "put the cue through his fingers". When asked what his favourite shot is, Jude replied: "A trick shot."



A stone-skimming champion from Pembrokeshire has been invited to be head judge at Argentina's first national contest in Patagonia this week. Phillip Bloxham, 35, who won the Welsh title in 2024, has been a passionate skimmer since boyhood. His longest skim is 157 metres, and the most skips he has achieved with one stone is 99. Both surpass the official world records, but as they did not take place at official events, they are not included. The tips and videos that Bloxham posts on social media led to his invitation to Patagonia.

Mandelson's fall

When Peter Mandelson was asked by the Financial Times about his relationship with Jeffrey Epstein in February 2025, his response was nothing if not "forthright", said Bagehot in The Economist. "I'm not going to go into this," snapped the soon-to-be ambassador to Washington. "It's an FT obsession and frankly you can all fuck off. OK?" Exactly a year on, Mandelson's career is over. Sacked as ambassador in September, he has now quit the Labour Party and stepped down from the House of Lords, as a result of damning new evidence about his relationship with the late paedophile that has embroiled Keir Starmer's Government in "Britain's worst political scandal of this century". Email exchanges released in the US appear to show that, as governments battled the aftermath of the financial crash, Mandelson shared "market-sensitive information" with Epstein, including about a \$500bn EU bailout. Mandelson is facing a criminal investigation over possible misconduct in public office; police have searched two of his homes.

As evidence of Mandelson's duplicitous behaviour mounted last week, Keir Starmer put on "his best shocked and angry face", said Tom Slater in The Spectator. But surely he could have seen this coming. "Every big job Mandelson has ever held has ended in scandal." He has twice been forced to resign from Labour cabinets: first in 1998, over an undeclared £373,000 loan from his wealthy colleague Geoffrey Robinson;



A photo from the Epstein files

then again in 2001, owing to his efforts to get a British passport for the Indian billionaire Srichand Hinduja. Later, as an EU trade commissioner, he faced intense scrutiny over his relationship with a Russian oligarch who'd benefitted from tariff cuts he'd introduced. As for his friendship with Epstein, this was in the public domain long before he was lined up to replace the "highly capable Dame Karen Pierce" in Washington, said Gordon Raynor in The Daily Telegraph. He was known to have attended "intimate gatherings" at Epstein's palatial Manhattan townhouse, and to have stayed there in 2009, when the financier was in jail for soliciting prostitution from a minor. Yet Starmer still saw fit to entrust him with the top job in British diplomacy.

It's worth remembering, said Jeremy Warner in the same paper, that many observers at the time thought Mandelson's appointment was "inspired". If anyone could "smooth-talk the Trump administration" into giving Britain a decent trade deal, the thinking went, it was "the Prince of Darkness": he would move easily in the circles that surrounded the new president. It's also the case that he is a brilliant operator, said Daniel Finkelstein in The Times. As one of New Labour's key architects, Mandelson has been a "transformative" figure in modern British politics. Yet for all his political nous, he has kept on flying too close to the Sun in pursuit of the wealth and connections he feels he deserves – despite repeatedly getting burned. Now he is accused of passing "state secrets" to a criminal, and is paying the price.

The King speaks out

For decades, their mantra was "never complain, never explain"; yet now, senior royals are "singing like canaries", said Jane Moore in The Sun. First, Prince William and his wife Catherine responded to the "ongoing saga" of Andrew Mountbatten-Windsor's "tawdry" dealings with Jeffrey Epstein by issuing a "vague statement" expressing their "deep concern" and sympathy for the deceased paedophile's victims. Then, Buckingham Palace said that King Charles and Queen Camilla also shared "profound concern" at the latest allegations – and confirmed that the Palace is ready to assist Thames Valley Police in its investigation into Andrew.

The Palace issued the statement in response to the emergence of more "jaw-dropping" evidence about the ex-prince's relationship with Epstein, said The Guardian. It seems that, while working as a UK trade envoy, he may have passed confidential documents to Epstein. The Epstein files seem also to confirm that – contrary to what Andrew has always



The former prince at Windsor

insisted – the infamous photo of him with the late Virginia Giuffrè is genuine. Insiders say the Palace was appalled by these revelations, said Kate Mansey in The Times. Courtiers were also enraged by photos of Andrew "grinning and waving" while out and about near Royal Lodge last week – which accelerated his move from Windsor to the Sandringham Estate. But questions remain for the King and Prince William, both of whom have been heckled about the scandal in the past few days. People want to know what the family knew about Andrew and Epstein and, crucially, when; and to know why the Palace so readily accepted Andrew's timeline and version of events. The Palace's security records presumably show when Epstein visited royal residences, and what he did there.

It's sad to see the late Queen's legacy tarnished, but there are also questions to be asked about her failure to rein Andrew in, said Jennie Bond in The i Paper. Did she let her maternal love cloud her judgement when allegations against him started to be made? And should she have cast him out of the Firm before that fateful Newsnight interview?

THE WEEK

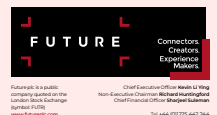
Crumbling masonry; mouse infestations; leaking pipes; ancient wiring – the deteriorating condition of the Palace of Westminster is all too emblematic of the ragged state of governance in Britain over recent years. The same could be said of parliamentarians' efforts to fix the problem, which appear to be stuck in an endless holding pattern. In 2012, a study found that "fundamental renovation can no longer be avoided", and in 2018 MPs and peers agreed in principle to move to temporary facilities near the site to allow these essential repairs to be made. They set up an outside body to direct the operation, but then shelved that body's restoration plan because of the high cost, estimated at between £7bn and £13bn. Last week, an internal board presented MPs and peers with two new options. One involves a "full decant" of the building for between 19 and 24 years, and would cost up to £15.6bn. The other involves a "staged decant" and could take up to 61 years and cost up to £39.2bn. The board called on MPs to choose between these options by the middle of 2030. In the meantime, it pointed out, £1.5m a week would keep being spent on maintenance and running repairs. Witnessing this agonisingly drawn-out process, it's hard not to envy the Austrians. In 2014, their legislators voted for a root-and-branch renovation of their (admittedly much smaller) 19th century parliament building. They vacated it in 2017, and by 2023, they were back in again, all the work completed. If only we'd cracked on at the same brisk pace.

Harry Nicolle

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Controversy of the week

Grinding graduates down

A political storm is brewing over student loans, said the FT – and you can see why. Today's graduates not only face higher housing, commuting and childcare costs than previous generations, they're having to cover these while having 9% of their salary above a certain threshold deducted to repay their student loans. There are five different loan schemes currently in operation; and the five million or so graduates who entered university in England and Wales between 2012 and 2023, and are on the Plan 2 version of the loan, have reason to be particularly unhappy. Whereas the interest rate on other loans is set at the RPI measure of inflation, Plan 2 people are charged RPI plus up to 3%, depending on earnings. At the top end, people are currently paying 6.2% interest. The result is that in many cases their debt will keep ballooning even when they start making repayments. It's thought that nearly three-quarters of Plan 2 graduates will never fully repay their loans, which are wiped after 30 years. Middle-earners will end up paying the most.

Tell me about it, said Charlotte Ivers in The Sunday Times. As the owner of a Plan 2 loan, I can attest to its demoralising effect, particularly now that the Chancellor is freezing the repayment threshold for three years at just under £30,000, rather than letting it rise with inflation, as it was meant to. The 9% surcharge means that a graduate who earns over £50,270pa – enough to pay the higher-rate income tax – takes home only 49% of their earnings above that. Above £100,000, they take home 31%. I know people who've opted not to pursue promotions or better jobs, as their income won't go up enough to make it worth the extra effort. The loan system is acting as "a tax on aspiration".

There's nothing wrong with the principle of graduates with decent salaries contributing to the cost of their education, said Emma Duncan in The Times. It's unfair, though, that different cohorts are facing different repayment terms, and having their terms changed over time. Graduates are also being asked to shoulder too much of the financial burden. "In Britain, the state pays around a quarter of the total bill for universities – less than in any other rich country. The OECD average is two-thirds." We should value higher education more. Let's "cut" the welfare bill, "bin" the pensions triple lock, and "spend the money on people who are going to make the country more, not less, productive". The student loan system is an unsustainable mess, said The Independent. When Tony Blair's government introduced the concept of students contributing to the costs of higher education in 1998, tuition fees were capped at £1,000. Since then, graduates – who "pay more tax in any case" by virtue of generally earning more – have found themselves funding an ever-larger chunk of the budget, and it's "beginning to blight both their lives and the sector, and thus the national economy".



Facing "a tax on aspiration"?

Trump's Chagos U-turn

Donald Trump has dropped his opposition to the UK's Chagos Islands deal, weeks after labelling it an "act of great stupidity". Under the deal agreed last year, which Parliament has yet to approve, the UK will give Mauritius the Indian Ocean archipelago, and pay £3.4bn for a 99-year lease to secure the US-UK military base on the island of Diego Garcia. Washington approved the deal at the time, and following a call with Keir Starmer last week, Trump said it was the best deal the PM "could get". However, he vowed to "militarily secure" the US's presence should the lease be jeopardised.

Threat to universities

The head of MI5 has warned that British universities face a growing threat from China and other countries. At a briefing last week, Sir Ken McCallum urged 70 vice-chancellors to be on high alert, and gave them advice about how to prevent intimidation by hostile actors seeking to influence research and teaching on topics such as the 1989 Tiananmen Square massacre. The Government has promised £3m worth of measures to help universities in this regard, including a hotline – the Academic Interference Reporting Route – they can use to report threats to staff.

Spirit of the age

HMP Norwich is looking for a pagan chaplain to support the growing number of its inmates who subscribe to the ancient tradition. Applicants to the part-time position, which offers a salary of nearly £38k pro rata, must be verified members of the pagan community, with theological competence across more than one pagan tradition.

A pizzeria in north London has caused consternation among foodies by launching a sticky toffee pudding pizza. Circus Pizza's creation features a sourdough base topped with caramel sauce, soft honey cake and a dash of cream (plus extra caramel on top). Sticky Toffee Pudding Guy, an Instagram user who reviews sticky toffee puddings, called the pizza "an abomination" and said it "should be illegal".

Good week for:

Ducks, which have been enjoying lovely weather – for them.

According to the Met Office, it has either rained or poured every day of the year so far in some parts of the country. This week, around 100 flood warnings were in place across the UK.

Noel Gallagher, who was announced as the winner of the BRIT songwriter of the year award – despite not having recorded any new songs this year. Critics said the award should not be used to recognise lifetime achievement. In response, the Oasis musician pointed to his sales this year, and said he'd be at the ceremony, and "if anybody's got a problem with it, meet me there".

Bad week for:

Apologies, after a Norwegian Olympic biathlete's public plea for forgiveness from the ex-girlfriend on whom he cheated seemed to fall on deaf ears. After winning a bronze medal on Tuesday, a tearful Sturla Holm Lægreid told the world it was the "worst week of my life", because his girlfriend of six months, "the love of my life", had broken up with him over his infidelity. The next day the unnamed ex replied, saying "it is hard to forgive".

Tesco, after shoppers spotted that bilingual signs erected in a branch in Cornwall were in Welsh. A local councillor welcomed the effort at the Helston branch, but suggested that it would be better if the signs could be in Kernowek, the Cornish language.

Farmers, with claims the use of appetite-suppressing "skinny jabs" is affecting sales of spuds. One big grower reports orders from supermarkets and food manufacturers have fallen by 5% to 7% year on year. Others cite sales slumps of as much as 10%.

Poll watch

A quarter of working-age people say they would run out of money within a month if they lost their jobs. Half say they wouldn't last more than three months. *YouGov/The Times*

59% of US adults believe their life will be good in about five years, the lowest measure of optimism since the poll began almost 20 years ago. Only around **48%** of Americans are now categorised by Gallup as "thriving" – which means they rate their current life at seven out of ten or higher, and estimate their future life at eight or higher. *The Independent/Gallup*

29% of clergy could be suffering from depression, a survey of 500 CofE priests has found. Four in ten feel isolated in their ministry. *Living Ministry*

The Hague, the Netherlands

TikTok arrests: Fifteen people – four of them under 18 – have been arrested in the Netherlands on suspicion of disseminating Islamic State propaganda on the social media platform TikTok. The suspects, 13 of whom were described as Syrian nationals, were detained in a series of raids in The Hague and other towns and cities. They are accused of inciting terrorist crimes, spreading extremist material, and being part of a terrorist group. A nationwide investigation was launched last year, following the discovery of a TikTok account that posted Isis videos with Dutch subtitles. Some of the posts, which urged people to join Isis and glorified “martyrdom”, had attracted more than 100,000 views. The raids followed the arrest on 20 January of an individual described as the “main suspect”. Police expressed concern about the amount of extremist content on TikTok, and refused to rule out more arrests related to it.

Brussels

Asylum reform: The European Parliament has approved reforms to the asylum rules to fast-track rejections, and allow failed applicants to be transferred to “safe” third countries outside the bloc. MEPs have also backed the introduction of an EU-wide list of countries deemed “safe”. The measures – which need final approval from member states – could provide fresh legal backing for Italy’s plan to process some asylum claims in Albania, an arrangement that has been challenged in Italian courts. The Netherlands has agreed in principle a similar deal with Uganda. The legislation was passed with strong backing from centre-right and right-wing groups. But the rule changes drew heavy criticism from human rights organisations, which pointed to widespread rights abuses in some of the “safe countries of origin”, which include Bangladesh, Tunisia and Egypt. Refugees from these countries will be presumed not to be in need of protection.

Bourg-lès-Valence, France

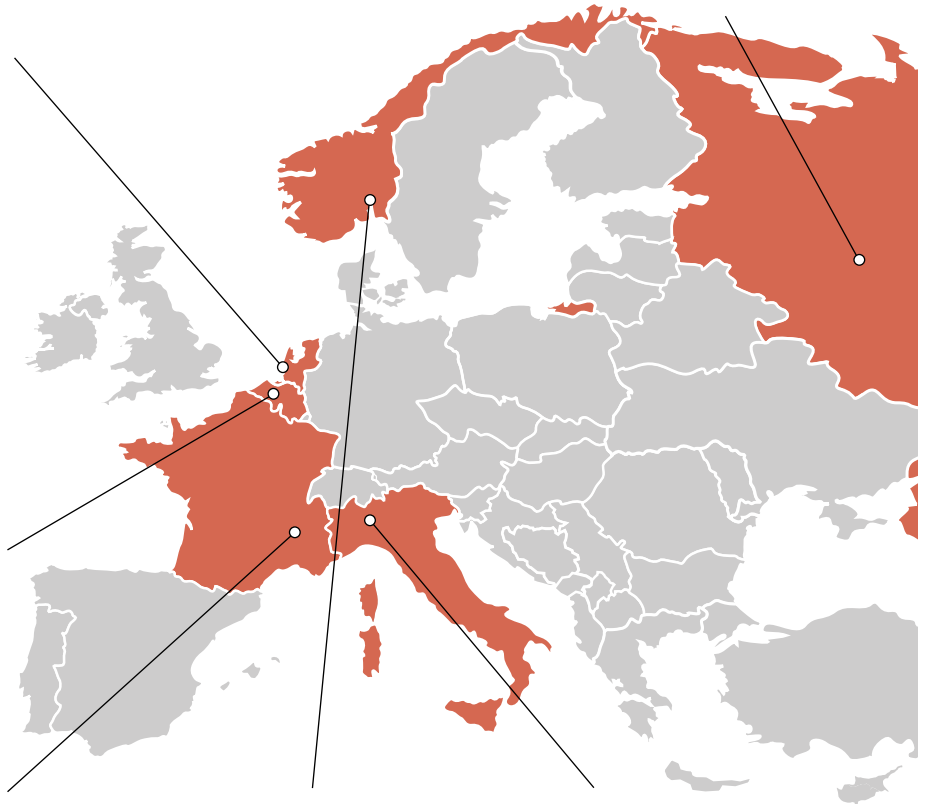
Crypto kidnapping: A magistrate and her 67-year-old mother became the latest victims last week of a spate of kidnappings targeting cryptocurrency investors in France. The women were seized from the 35-year-old magistrate’s house in a village near Grenoble by a masked gang. The attackers left them tied up in a garage about 60 miles away in the town of Bourg-lès-Valence. Soon after, the magistrate’s partner – who works for a crypto startup – received a €1.6m ransom demand, with threats to mutilate the women later that day. Police launched a massive search operation, involving 160 personnel. However, the women managed to escape their bonds and after banging on the door for help, they were freed by a passerby. Police have since arrested one minor, and five other people (four men and a woman) aged between 18 and 20. They were reportedly planning to flee to Spain.

Moscow

Assassination attempt: Russia has accused Polish intelligence of being involved in the attempted assassination in Moscow of one of its top generals, which it says was ordered by Ukraine. Lt Gen Vladimir Alexeyev (pictured), second-in-command of Russia’s military intelligence agency, the GRU, was shot in the stairway of a residential building in the city’s suburbs last Friday. His assailant fled the scene. But Moscow said this week that it has two suspects in custody, including the alleged shooter – a Ukraine-born Russian citizen in his 60s named Lyubomir Korba. He was arrested in Dubai and extradited to Moscow. Kyiv has denied involvement; Warsaw has not yet commented on the allegation.



As talks between the UK, Kyiv and Moscow continued last week, President Zelensky released his first update on Ukrainian casualties since 2024. He said that 55,000 Ukrainian soldiers had been killed to date, with “large numbers” missing. His figure is rather lower than the estimate produced by a US think-tank last month. It concluded that Ukraine had lost about 140,000 troops, and Russia 320,000.



Oslo

Scandal widens: A senior Norwegian diplomat and her husband are being investigated



by the police over their links to Jeffrey Epstein. Mona Juul and her husband Terje Rød-Larsen – a former diplomat – crop up repeatedly in the Epstein files. They seem to have visited his private island in 2011; Rød-Larsen appears to have dined with Epstein just before his arrest, in 2019; and their children appear to have been left \$5m each in Epstein’s will. The investigation is said to be focused on any benefits received in connection to her position. They deny criminal wrongdoing, but Juul resigned as ambassador to Iraq and Jordan this week.

Milan, Italy

Olympic protests: The US vice-president, J.D. Vance, and his wife Usha were booed last week at the ceremony to mark the opening of the Winter Olympics in Milan. The next day, thousands of people took to the streets of the city to demonstrate against the Games: many Italians are angry about the cost of staging the event, and its environmental impact. Protesters let off smoke bombs and firecrackers near the Olympic village; police used water cannon and tear gas to disperse them. Over the weekend, saboteurs targeted railway lines near Pescara and Bologna, causing significant delays to services and impacting thousands of passengers. An anarchist group later claimed responsibility for the attacks, saying it was a response to “growing repression” by the right-wing government. PM Giorgia Meloni denounced both the saboteurs and the protesters as “enemies of Italy”.

Tumbler Ridge, Canada

School shooting: Nine people have been killed and at least 27 injured in a horrific killing spree carried out in the remote coal-mining town of Tumbler Ridge, some 700 miles northeast of Vancouver. Six of the victims were shot dead inside the local secondary school; a seventh died on the way to hospital. The two other killings took place at a nearby house. The suspected killer, whose body was found on the floor of the school, appears to have died from a self-inflicted injury. The police say they know the identity of the suspected shooter, but have so far declined to provide details other than to say the suspect was a “female in a dress with brown hair”. Tumbler Ridge is a tiny town of little more than 2,400 people. “I will know every victim,” the grieving mayor, Darryl Krakowka, told reporters. “We’re a small community. I don’t call them residents. I call them family.”

Washington DC

Racist video: Donald Trump has refused to apologise for posting a video on his Truth Social account depicting Barack and Michelle Obama as apes. The racist clip was tagged onto the end of a separate 62-second video promoting conspiracy theories about the 2020 election. Reacting to the furious objections of Democrats, the White House had initially defended the post; but it was taken down 12 hours later after a rare public condemnation from a series of Republican senators. Following this unprecedented reversal, Trump insisted he hadn’t “made a mistake” in approving the post. It was his aides, he surmised, who’d posted the video and neither he nor they had watched the whole thing to the end.

**Tucson, Arizona**

Guthrie kidnapping: NBC news anchor Savannah Guthrie issued a desperate plea for information in a video posted on social media over a week after her mother was abducted from her home near Tucson, and the day before a \$6m ransom demand expired. A man was held for questioning, but has since been released. Nancy Guthrie, 84, was reported missing on 1 February. Police found blood splatter on

her porch, and said a doorbell camera had been covered. The FBI had warned the ransom demand could have been from impostors.

Havana

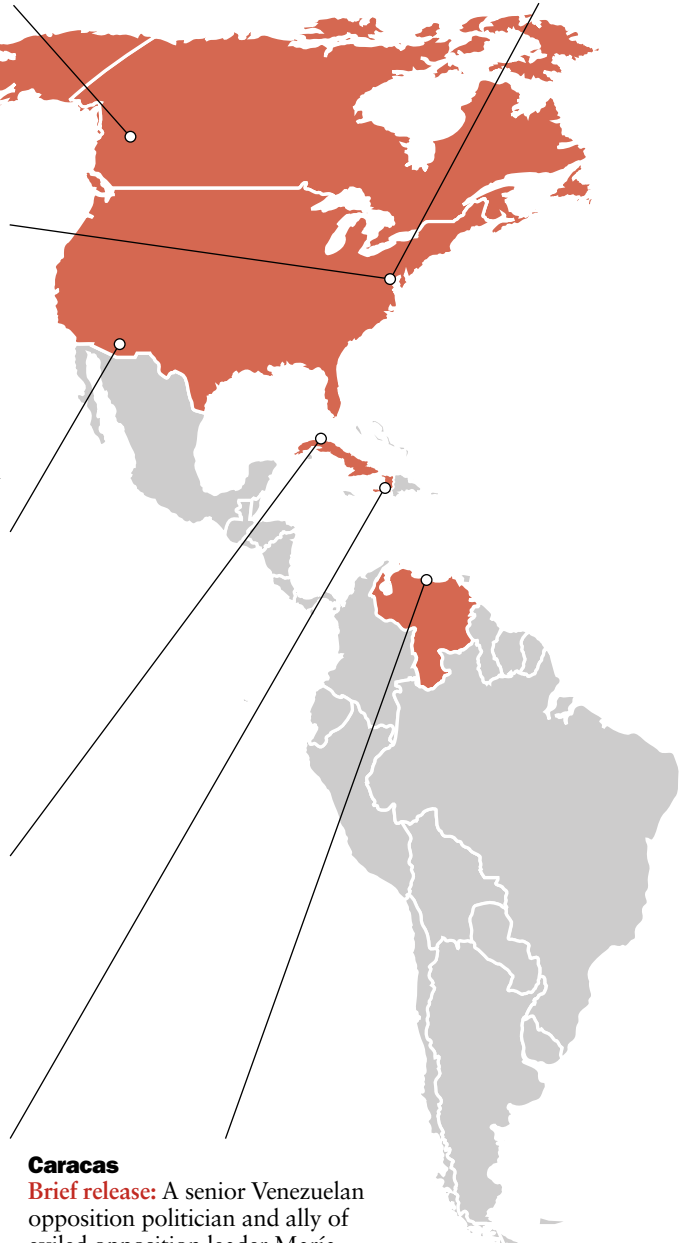
Fuel squeeze: A drastic oil shortage in Cuba, brought about by US sanctions, has forced the communist government to close Cuba’s universities and – as planes can no longer refuel there – to cancel many international flights. The shortage is the direct result of President Trump’s ever-tighter squeeze on the regime, which began when Washington banned Venezuela’s new government from shipping oil to Cuba. Cuba has its own oil sufficient for up to 40% of its needs, but relies heavily on Venezuela for the rest. Mexico is its other key supplier, but it too has felt obliged to cut off supply after Trump’s threat of imposing tariffs on any nation providing Havana with energy. With its reserves looking as if they could run out by March, Havana has now had to declare further emergency measures, including the closure of some tourist resorts.

Port-au-Prince

Power play: After two years of unstable rule, Haiti’s Transitional Presidential Council (TPC) has been pressured to hand all power over to the US-backed prime minister, Alix Didier Fils-Aimé. The TPC was set up two years ago, tasked with suppressing the gangs that control up to 90% of the capital, Port-au-Prince, and restoring order in the wake of the chaos unleashed by the gang-related assassination of the president, Jovenel Moïse, in 2021. Shortly before the TPC’s mandate expired last week, council members had tried to oust Fils-Aimé from the PM role they’d awarded the businessman in 2024. Washington reacted by stripping them of their US travel visas and sending a warship to Haiti. Fils-Aimé has vowed to hold an election soon; given ongoing gang violence, which killed thousands of Haitians last year, this seems unlikely.

**Washington DC**

Epstein silence: Ghislaine Maxwell appeared before the US House Oversight Committee in an online deposition conducted from her Texas prison cell this week. The lawmakers wanted her to reveal the names of “the powerful men” involved in Jeffrey Epstein’s crimes, but Maxwell invoked the Fifth Amendment, which gives her the right to refuse to answer questions under oath to avoid self-incrimination. She’d speak openly, said her lawyer, if Trump granted her clemency. In October, the Supreme Court rejected her appeal against her conviction for procuring underage girls for Epstein.

**Caracas**

Brief release: A senior Venezuelan opposition politician and ally of exiled opposition leader María Corina Machado was let out of jail this week, only to be placed under house arrest hours later. Former state governor Juan Pablo Guanipa, a political scientist, was one of at least 30 political prisoners freed this week; the number let out since the overthrow of Nicolás Maduro last month is at least 300. The authorities said Guanipa had violated the conditions of his release, but gave no further details. The interior minister, Diosdado Cabello, is suspected of ordering the detention: he and other regime hardliners oppose moves by Venezuela’s de facto leader, former vice-president Delcy Rodríguez, to placate Washington and introduce reforms.

Tehran

Reformists arrested: The crackdown on dissent in Iran broadened this week, with the arrest of at least seven senior members of the country's reformist movement, including its leader Azar Mansouri. The Reformists Front coalition – which helped propel President Masoud Pezeshkian to victory in elections in 2024 – had recently publicly condemned Tehran's brutal response to last month's mass protests. In a draft statement, reformist leaders had also called on Ayatollah Ali Khamenei to step down. Analysts say the arrests were designed as a message to ordinary Iranians and to the wider world that, despite US threats, the regime was still in control. Talks between the US and Iran over Iran's nuclear programme, designed to avoid a major conflict, were held in Oman this week, and are expected to continue at a later date.

Tokyo

Landslide win: Japan's PM Sanae Takaichi has led her conservative government to a landslide victory in a snap election, dramatically strengthening her grip on power. Takaichi's Liberal Democratic Party (LDP) won 316 of 465 seats; its coalition partner won 36. The result is a major reversal of fortune for the LDP, which has been in power for most of the past 70 years, but which had lost its majority. Appointed by MPs in October, Takaichi – Japan's first female premier – called the election to capitalise on her high personal approval ratings, especially among young voters.

Takaichi's 16-day campaign was centred around her tough stance towards China over Taiwan and her expansionary fiscal agenda. A plan to suspend Japan's 8% consumption tax on food went down particularly well with an electorate struggling with the cost of living. Owing to poor harvests, panic buying and demand from record visitor numbers, the price of rice has risen by 67.5% since the start of 2025. However, with the national debt running around 230% of GDP (the highest level in the developed world), critics have questioned how the markets will respond to her agenda, warning of a possible "Liz Truss shock" if she goes through with it.



Hong Kong

Lai's "death sentence": The media mogul and dual British national Jimmy Lai has been jailed for 20 years by a court in Hong Kong. It is the harshest penalty meted out so far under Beijing's controversial national security law. Supporters of the 78-year-old, whose now-defunct Apple Daily newspaper backed anti-Beijing protests in 2019, called it a "death sentence". Lai has already been in prison for more than five years. Six former Apple Daily executives were also jailed, for up to ten years.

West Bank, Palestinian Territories

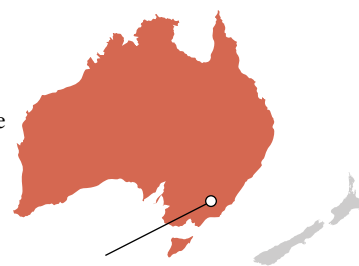
"De facto annexation": Israel's security cabinet has approved new measures to extend Israel's control over the occupied West Bank, plans that its critics say amount to de facto annexation. Israel's far-right finance minister, Bezalel Smotrich, said the package, which must now be approved by Israel's army commander in the West Bank, would make it easier for Jews to settle there, and "kill the idea of a Palestinian state". Israeli settlements (regarded as illegal under international law) expanded rapidly last year. The new measures include the lifting of a ban on the direct sale of land to Jews – a move Palestinians say will lead to more pressure on locals to sell up, and encourage forgery and fraud.



Johannesburg, South Africa

Water crisis: There were protests in Johannesburg this week about water outages that have left some residents without supplies for up to 20 days. The city is in the grip of

a deepening water crisis, the result of years of underinvestment in infrastructure at a time of rapid population growth, which has been exacerbated lately by water workers going on strike. Some schools and businesses have had to close, and with temperatures reaching around 30°C, there have been long queues at community water tankers. Similar problems have been affecting parts of Pretoria and Cape Town.



Canberra

Slogans ban: The use of the slogans "From the river to the sea" and "Globalise the intifada" is to be partially outlawed in Queensland. A new bill, drawn up in response to December's terrorist attack on Bondi Beach, imposes jail terms of up to two years for those who use the phrases in order to cause menace or offence; it also expands a ban on antisemitic symbols to include the emblems of Hamas and Hezbollah. The bill was introduced to parliament this week during a four-day visit to Australia by the Israeli president, Isaac Herzog.

Chasing the carrot

Francis Rossi has spent six decades leading Status Quo. The band may never have been fashionable, but they have sold more than 118 million albums, and produced a host of singalong classics such as *Rockin' All Over the World* and *Whatever You Want*. As a result, Rossi – who grew up in a working-class Italian family in south London – has millions of loyal fans. Yet at 76, he sometimes wonders why he keeps doing it, says Will Hodgkinson in *The Times*. Recently, he was asked if he'd like to make a solo album, "and I thought, not really. Get a quarter of a penny for every download... what's the point?" But then he did some recording, and found that he rather enjoyed it. "I started thinking about this word 'creativity', which is a bit of a contradiction if you're the bloke in Status Quo." It's the latest chapter in a career fuelled by a seemingly unquenchable need to prove himself. "Ever since I started, it's been 'no'," he says, a touch gloomily. "You can't have a gig, we don't like your band, we don't like the songs. Yesterday I was told a song of mine hadn't made it onto a BBC radio playlist. Why is that so important to me? It just is." Showbusiness, he says, is "like a hospital gown. Looks good at the front but round the back your arse is hanging out." But surely, Quo's success has brought him some satisfaction? "No. I want more," he says. "Not in a materialistic way, but why do I keep trying? Where

do I think I'm going at 76?" He whispers conspiratorially. "I want people to like me, to like the music, and it never satisfies. The album goes double platinum and you think, why didn't it go triple platinum? I'm still chasing the carrot."

The real job of an exorcist

Jason Bray has an unusual sideline: as well as being an Anglican priest, he is one of the Church of England's specialist "deliverance ministers" – or exorcists. The role, he told Abigail Buchanan in *The Daily Telegraph*, is not quite as it is portrayed in films. He doesn't burst into houses clutching a crucifix: he turns up to fix a problem like "a gas engineer, but for paranormal activity". Called out about a dozen times a year, he works in homes, offices and even shops. In one case, the family were having to step over a "person" with a broken neck who kept appearing at the bottom of the stairs. In another, the individual kept getting "jump scares" in the shower from the sight of a deceased relative behind the curtain. He also works with mental health teams to assist people who "believe they are possessed by a demon". Actual possessions are extremely rare, he says. The three signs are "preternatural strength; preternatural knowledge; and knowledge of languages they never learnt to speak". Those cases might require "a major exorcism". Otherwise, his toolkit consists of a sprinkling of holy water and the Lord's Prayer. "Usually that works."



Denise Welch has spent most of the past three decades in the public eye – as a star of *Coronation Street* in the late 1990s; as a regular on TV's *Loose Women* known for her outspoken views, from 2005; and more recently, as the mother of rock star Matty Healy. Now, at 67, her career is going into overdrive: she is in demand for acting roles, and is also being held up as a style icon, with features in fashion magazines and her own entourage. "I'd always been a bit jealous of people who had a team," she explains – so she hired a stylist, a hairdresser and a publicist, and in this way she helped create her own "renaissance". It's great to see her in such good form, says Simon Hattenstone in *The Guardian*, because she hasn't always been. For years, she struggled with depression, and when that led to alcohol and drug addiction, she became a target for the tabloid press. Her phone was hacked; her hotel rooms were bugged; and she was pursued relentlessly by the paparazzi. At the height of the intrusion, when her private conversations were making their way into the papers, she began to distrust even her closest friends. "I was so paranoid," she recalls. She only found out the truth in the mid-2010s, when police presented her with the evidence. "You sit at Putney police station and there's a spreadsheet of years of your life, phone calls you made, places they'd rented across from you to spy on you for two weeks. And you're thinking, 'Oh my God!'"

Castaway of the week

This week's edition of Radio 4's Desert Island Discs featured the costume and effects designer Tahra Zafar

- 1 *Thunderbirds (Main Theme)* by Barry Gray, performed by The Barry Gray Orchestra
- 2 *Gee, Officer Krupke* by Leonard Bernstein and Stephen Sondheim, performed by Leo Kharibian, Norman Furber and Vince Logan
- 3 *Symphony No. 9* by Beethoven, performed by the Berlin Philharmoniker and Wiener Singverein (cond. Herbert von Karajan)
- 4 *Brazil*, written and performed by Geoff Muldaur
- 5 *Sir Duke*, written and performed by Stevie Wonder
- 6 *Groove is in the Heart* by Dmitry Brill, Towa Tei, Kieran Kirby, Herbie Hancock and Jonathan Davis, performed by Deee-Lite
- 7* *Eclipse* by Roger Waters, performed by Pink Floyd
- 8 *Take Five* by Paul Desmond, performed by the Dave Brubeck Quartet

* Choice if allowed only one record

Book: Omnibus edition of *The Hitchhiker's Guide to the Galaxy*
Luxury: a cabinet full of art supplies

Viewpoint:**Apostrophe crimes**

"I have found the most egregious use of an apostrophe in history. It is an advert for, and I quote, WALE'S LARGEST VAPE SHOP. I'm no pedant, and I appreciate it's tricky to know where to put a possessive apostrophe when the word ends in the letter S, but – ye gods! – this is quite something. And it was only when I'd photographed it for posterity that I realised (so entranced had I been at the WALE'S) I'd missed CHEAPEST PRICE'S. It's weird, because I can't see any such aberrations on the company's rather well-put-together website. It might even all be a ruse to grab attention. If so, it's worked a treat with me." *Adrian Chiles in The Guardian*

Farewell

John Burton, Labour agent who "discovered" Tony Blair, died 6 February, aged 85.

Saif al-Islam Gaddafi, son of Colonel Gaddafi and Libyan politician who was indicted by the ICC for war crimes, died 3 February, aged 53.

Joan Hall, Yorkshire's first female Conservative MP, died 27 January, aged 90.

John Virgo, UK snooker champion who became a TV star, died 4 February, aged 79.

Asad Rehman, CEO – Friends of the Earth

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A broken water system

It is widely acknowledged that the water companies that serve England and Wales are failing. How did we get here?

What's wrong with the system?

Bills have gone up – Ofwat estimates that they will be 67% higher in real terms in 2025-2030 than they were in 1989-1994 – but customers widely believe they are receiving a worse service. Some have suffered serious outages, most recently in Kent and Sussex, where about 30,000 households were left without water for up to six days in January. Many complain of low pressure and the regular imposition of hosepipe bans, when an estimated three billion litres of water are lost to leaks every day in England and Wales. By far the biggest complaint, though, is about pollution: water companies discharged untreated waste into England's rivers and seas 450,398 times in 2024. Some 14,500 sewage overflow pipes, which are meant only to operate in emergencies, discharged for a total of 3.6 million hours. Just 15% of rivers in England are deemed to be in good health.



A campaign group's warning sign in Oxfordshire

expenditure and investment plans that have turned out to be flawed and had a negative impact on the sector. As for the Environment Agency, its enforcement funding was cut by nearly two-thirds between 2010 and 2021, from £120m to just £43m, seriously hindering its efficacy.

How much is privatisation to blame?

Cunliffe concluded that the first ten to 15 years of privatisation were a partial success: they mobilised capital and infrastructure works that the publicly owned system had struggled to secure. Drinking-water quality improved; leakages fell. But from the early 2000s, privatisation led to grave problems. Water companies, often in the hands of foreign investors or private equity firms, accumulated large debts and

began paying substantial dividends, which arguably prevented investment. By 2023, the companies collectively owed more than £64bn in debt, but had extracted dividends of more than £78bn (since privatisation). Some, notably Thames Water, have been brought to the brink of financial collapse (see box). Yet they have continued to pay huge salaries and bonuses: in the 2024/25 financial year, the average pay of water company chief executives reached £1.1m.

How is the water system structured?

The industry was privatised in 1989, when the ten publicly owned water and sewerage authorities that served England and Wales were floated on the London Stock Exchange. Under the Water Act 1989, the government wrote off their debts to the tune of £5bn, and gave them a “green dowry” of £1.5bn between them to fund infrastructure improvements. Now, there are 11 large regional water and wastewater companies in England and Wales, and only three of them are still listed on the stock exchange. Seven are privately owned by investor consortiums; Welsh Water operates as a not-for-profit. Scotland's water, meanwhile, remains largely in public ownership. Water companies are regulated by four independent bodies: Ofwat (which sets price controls and supervises economic matters); the Environment Agency (which leads on pollution in England); Natural Resources Wales (which does the same in Wales); and the Drinking Water Inspectorate.

And what's behind the problems?

Insufficient investment in pipes, sewage systems and other infrastructure has left the network in a very poor condition. This is the consensus, encapsulated in last year's independent review led by Jon Cunliffe, a former deputy governor of the Bank of England. At the same time, the system faces considerable strain from a population that has grown by millions since 1989, and from droughts and floods linked to climate change. Cunliffe also reflected a broad consensus that the existing regulatory framework has failed.

How have regulators failed?

Having multiple regulators with overlapping remits means no single body is accountable. Ofwat has historically prioritised keeping bills low, at the expense of investment in infrastructure. It lacks specialist engineering expertise, and has been accused of “regulatory capture” (having too cosy a relationship with the companies). It has until recently tolerated very poor environmental performance; and it has approved

Should the water companies be renationalised?

The then-environment minister, Steve Reed, prevented Cunliffe from considering renationalisation. The Government argued that buying back the water companies would be very expensive (the cost to the taxpayer is often put at around £100bn); that it would be complex administratively; and that the process would get bogged down in complex legal challenges, making it harder to address urgent issues such as pollution and investment. Cunliffe also concluded that comparable nationalised water systems were not necessarily better run than their privately owned counterparts. The campaign group We Own It, among others, disagrees, pointing out that Europe's best water utilities, from Austria to Greece, are all publicly owned.

The unacceptable face of privatisation

England is unusual in its reliance on the private sector to provide water services. It's the only country in Europe to have fully sold its water infrastructure – including pipes, reservoirs, boreholes and treatment plants – to private owners. And for critics, the unacceptable face of privatisation is Thames Water, Britain's largest water company. After its flotation in 1989, Thames Water plc was bought first by the German utility company RWE, in 2001, and then in 2006 for £8bn by Kemble Water Holdings Ltd, a consortium led by the Australian banking group Macquarie. Kemble did invest in infrastructure, at a level of about £1bn per year, but Thames Water's debt – relatively cheap at the time – rose from about £3.4bn to around £10.8bn, while some £2.7bn was paid out in dividends to investors. Macquarie sold its share in 2017, having made 12%-13% annual returns. By 2024, Thames's debts had hit £15bn, and it was in deep crisis because, after necessary spending, it could not meet its growing debt obligations. Last year, it was given the worst pollution rating of any English water company. And its debts were so unmanageable that it needed a £3bn emergency loan. Ministers had to prevent Thames from paying its executives large bonuses from the loan.

What is the Government doing?

Last month, the Government set out its full response to the Cunliffe report in a White Paper. Ofwat will be abolished and replaced with a new all-powerful “super regulator” for England and Wales. This new body will be given powers to carry out “no notice” surprise inspections of sewage treatment works and other infrastructure; there will also be regular “MoT-style” checks on water infrastructure; and failing companies will be put into a “performance improvement regime”. Ministers have pledged to halve sewage overflow discharges by 2030. The hope is that regulation will be greatly improved, while the cash will flow into infrastructure improvements: £104bn has been promised by 2030. The one certainty is that consumers will pay: bills in England rose by 26% on average in 2025/26, and will rise by an average of 5.4% next year.

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Not “them and us” but “them and them”

Janan Ganesh

Financial Times

What you have to grasp about “the elite”, says Janan Ganesh, is that it’s not a monolith: it’s made up of two very different tribes. One, of course, is the super-rich, people brilliant at making money, yet with quite dull-sounding jobs. The other consists of prominent artists, intellectuals, politicians and the odd journalist. Poorer but seen as far more glamorous than the first, it thus enjoys far greater social cachet. And the gulf between the two tribes reveals itself at Davos: during the day, the journalists and politicians mix on equal footing with tycoons; at night, they retire to very different hotels. This gulf is what lies behind the rise and fall of Peter Mandelson. He had a gift for exploiting the insecurities of the wealthy, their niggling feeling that, despite their huge fortunes, they still hadn’t quite made it. He was beguiling to them because he came from the world of ideas, events and acclaim; he, in turn, envied their lavish wealth and sought it for himself. “They’re all the same,” people are now saying louder than ever after his fall, pointing their finger at “the establishment”. Yet “the problem is precisely that they aren’t”.

Green spaces that should be built on

Martha Gill

The Observer

Look at any satellite image of the UK, says Martha Gill, and one thing leaps out at you: the sheer number of golf courses. We have around 3,000 of them – the most in Europe; by some estimates they cover a third of our open green space. They’re the legacy of the golf craze that seized Britain in the 1980s and the 1990s, and turned golf into a multimillion-pound business. Private business moved in, “elbowing aside” municipal courses and traditional members’ clubs. That craze may have run its course, however: though the number of casual golf players is rising, fewer people today want to shell out for membership fees, which in England average about £900 a year. So though top-end clubs are still thriving, of course – Queenwood in Surrey is believed to charge a £200,000 joining fee and £15,000 annual subs – less exclusive ones are struggling: around one in six now face closure. Which may be no bad thing. The architect Russell Curtis has calculated that the area covered by London’s 95 golf courses could house 345,257 people. Golf’s loss could be the country’s gain.

A community spirit down the Dog and Duck

Simon Jenkins

The Guardian

Nigel Farage knows a popular cause when he sees one, says Simon Jenkins. But if he is being opportunistic in championing “the pub”, he’s also dead right. This is an institution that desperately needs support. Pubs aren’t like shops or cafés: they’re crucial neighbourhood hubs fulfilling a role similar to that once provided by the parish church. They bring communities together, preserve local history, offer sanctuary to the “gregarious and lonely” alike. That Britain has lost a quarter of its pubs since 2000 is a tragedy, and Rachel Reeves’s tax hikes on small businesses have only made it worse. Yet the Government is not unaware of the need to revivify “left-behind” communities. If only with a view to winning over Reform UK voters, it has announced an £800m extension to its £5bn Pride in Place scheme, aimed at turning ailing shops and cafés into not-for-profit social enterprises – mainly volunteer-run shops. About 130,000 of these have now been set up across the country, and they’re a great thing: but they only really work in places where there’s a sense of community, a shared spirit of place. And nothing better helps inculcate that spirit than a thriving pub.

What it really means to live in poverty

Tom Calver

The Sunday Times

Labour is out to fix child poverty. It claims 4.5 million children now fall into that category, 900,000 more than in 2010; and by 2030 it wants to see that total reduced by 550,000. But do such figures really mean much, asks Tom Calver. Headline poverty estimates are extrapolated from a family resources survey of 20,000 households, in which people list their pay and benefits. Yet it’s a flawed count; the 2023 survey recorded such households getting £191bn in welfare payments; administrative data shows they actually received £234bn. So, from next month, survey responses will be linked to the data; and that in itself will slash child poverty numbers. All of which raises a bigger question: do income-based measures, which take no account of such key variables as family assets and access to housing, really capture what it means to be poor? “Places like Liverpool have low income but good services; in Buckinghamshire it is the reverse.” Research shows that, at similar income levels, children in workless families are four times more likely to be materially deprived than children in working families. “Poverty is not just about money, and solving it can’t be either.”

IT MUST BE TRUE... I read it in the tabloids

Two German backpackers accidentally gatecrashed a wake in Thailand, having mistaken it for a restaurant. The tourists, who haven’t been named, were spotted entering the private event in Nakhon Si Thammarat and sitting down at a table. “I went over to speak with them, and they asked if the place was a food court,” recalled mourner Charantorn ChaloeMKiad. They had followed the smell of cooking. The pair were “mortified”, ChaloeMKiad said, and made to leave, but the deceased’s sister invited them to stay and served them iced milk and fried dough sticks.



Commemorative coins released by the Royal Australian Mint to mark the centenary of the birth of Queen Elizabeth II have been criticised for their poor resemblance to the late monarch. “Looks like she just ran into a wall,” one detractor said online. Others complained that she had been made to look like Mrs Doubtfire. The \$5 and 50 cent silver coins – which will not enter general circulation – have sold out nevertheless.

The World Anti-Doping Agency has said it will look into allegations that ski-jumpers are injecting hyaluronic acid into their penises to get the edge over the competition. According to the German newspaper Bild, athletes have been trying to enlarge their penises so that they are issued with bigger suits. Research by the science journal Frontiers has found that even a 2cm change in a suit can result in an extra 5.8 metres in the length of a jump. The injections are not without risk, however: Dr Eric Chung told The Guardian that they could result in penile pain, deformity, infection and, in rare cases, “loss of the penis”.

Jeff Bezos: cutting the legs off The Washington Post

The Washington Post was, until recently, among the US's most venerable papers, said Jill Abramson in *The Boston Globe*. Its reporting on the Watergate scandal under the legendary editor Ben Bradlee made history; the reporters responsible, Bob Woodward and Carl Bernstein, have inspired generations of journalists since; the paper's writers and photographers were admired the world over. Alas, the Post today is a shadow of that former self, and last week it announced that it is laying off more than 300 people – a third of its already pared-back staff. Its ranks of local and international reporters are being decimated, and the sports and books sections are to close. This is not a cut. It is “a mortal wound”. And nor should it be mistaken for a “media story”, said Peggy Noonan in *The Wall Street Journal*. These layoffs will leave “the capital of the most powerful nation on Earth” without a major newspaper – and “during the Trump administration no less”.

“It sucks when your job gets blown up,” said Scott McKay in *The American Spectator*. But let's face it: the Post's glory days are long over. The paper lost \$77m in 2023 and \$100m in 2024. Last year its weekday print circulation fell below 100,000 for the



Bezos and wife attending Paris Fashion Week

first time in 55 years, said John R. Puri in *National Review*. The companies that own The New York Times and The Wall Street Journal, meanwhile, are making record profits. You can't blame Jeff Bezos, who bought the Post in 2013 for \$250m, for rationalising the business. If all those fulminating about these cuts had actually read the output of the Post's now-unemployed journalists, they'd still have their jobs.

Bezos isn't bothered about the Post's operating losses, said Alex Kirshner on *Slate*. With a net worth of \$240bn, he could sustain them for “hundreds of lifetimes”. When he bought the paper, he made much of the fact that he wasn't driven purely by a profit motive. But latterly, he seems to have used his ownership of the Post to appease Donald Trump and so boost the fortunes of his other interests, such as Amazon and Blue Origin. He stepped in to stop the paper endorsing Kamala Harris for president – a decision that cost it 250,000 subscribers. He shifted the paper's opinion section to be more pro-Trump; he made not a squeak of protest when the FBI recently raided the home of a Post reporter, seizing her devices. Bezos hasn't just presided over the Post's decline; he's deliberately accelerated it, for the sake of “his own bottom line”.

How Trump is ripping off the US taxpayer

Paul Waldman

MS Now

“Even in a presidential term drowning in self-dealing”, said Paul Waldman, this latest act is “so brazen, so shameless, so stunning ... that it will stand out in history”. Donald Trump is suing the Internal Revenue Service for \$10bn because a contractor at the agency leaked documents in 2020 revealing that he'd paid only \$750 in federal income taxes that year. The damages would be paid directly to him and his sons. As head of the executive branch, Trump is essentially both claimant and defendant, and his “lackeys” will no doubt offer him a fat settlement for the illegal disclosure of tax returns – returns that, as a presidential nominee, he should have volunteered to have published. Trump has made a fortune from launching extortionate lawsuits against big media companies with the implicit message: “Pay me now, or I'll use the power of the federal government to punish you.” He has won payouts from Paramount (\$16m), ABC (\$15m), Meta (\$25m), YouTube (\$24.5m) and X/Twitter (\$10m). Cases against The New York Times, The Wall Street Journal and the BBC are pending. “Bound by neither principles nor shame”, the president is now demanding that American taxpayers “open up their own wallets and give him a payoff” of \$10bn. Why? “Because he can.”

It's absurd to talk about “stolen land”

Rich Lowry

National Review

I don't blame Billie Eilish for talking nonsense, says Rich Lowry – “as a pop star, it's practically part of her job description”. But her outburst at the Grammys, in which she railed against President Trump's immigration policy, saying “no one is illegal on stolen land”, needs to be challenged. It's a familiar refrain on the Left – and a distortion of history. There's no denying that we European settlers were, “at our worst, brutal and duplicitous in our dealings with Native Americans”, but it's simplistic to imply that this means we have no legitimate claim to US soil today. Early on, much of the new land was purchased. The deals might seem unfair to us now – Manhattan for some trinkets – but Native Americans, who had plenty of land, didn't think so at the time. And if we are guilty of stealing other territory, then “so is nearly everyone else in history, including Native Americans, who constantly dispossessed one another”. The Comanche, for instance, moved into the Great Plains from the northern Rocky Mountains, displacing the Apache. Elsewhere, there were endless battles between Cheyennes and Kiowas, Navajos and Pueblos, and so on. “In short, it wasn't exactly *Dances with Wolves*.” If no one is illegal on stolen land, then most of the world's borders have no meaning.

Melania is not Rapunzel in the tower

Maureen Dowd

The New York Times

“The riddle of the Slovenian Sphinx has been solved,” says Maureen Dowd. It turns out that, behind the First Lady's “exquisite mannequin's mask”, there is no mystery, no other woman straining to break free. She's exactly as chilly as she seems. That's the main, perhaps only, takeaway from the glossy new documentary about Melania Trump. Over the years, many liberals have harboured fantasies about her being “a secret member of the #resistance”. One day, they hoped, Melania would rebel against her constraints and renounce her husband and all his works. But it should have been clear from her response to the 6 January Capitol riots – as described in the memoir of her former aide and confidante Stephanie Grisham – that this was never going to happen. After rioters broke through the barricades, Grisham sent Melania a text: “Do you want to tweet that peaceful protests are the right of every American, but there is no place for lawlessness and violence?” Melania replied simply: “No.” She was busy preparing for a photo shoot about a rug she had chosen for the White House. The First Lady is “not Rapunzel in the tower”, pining to be saved. She's exactly “where she wants to be, in the bosom of a corrupt family that is prostituting the People's House”.

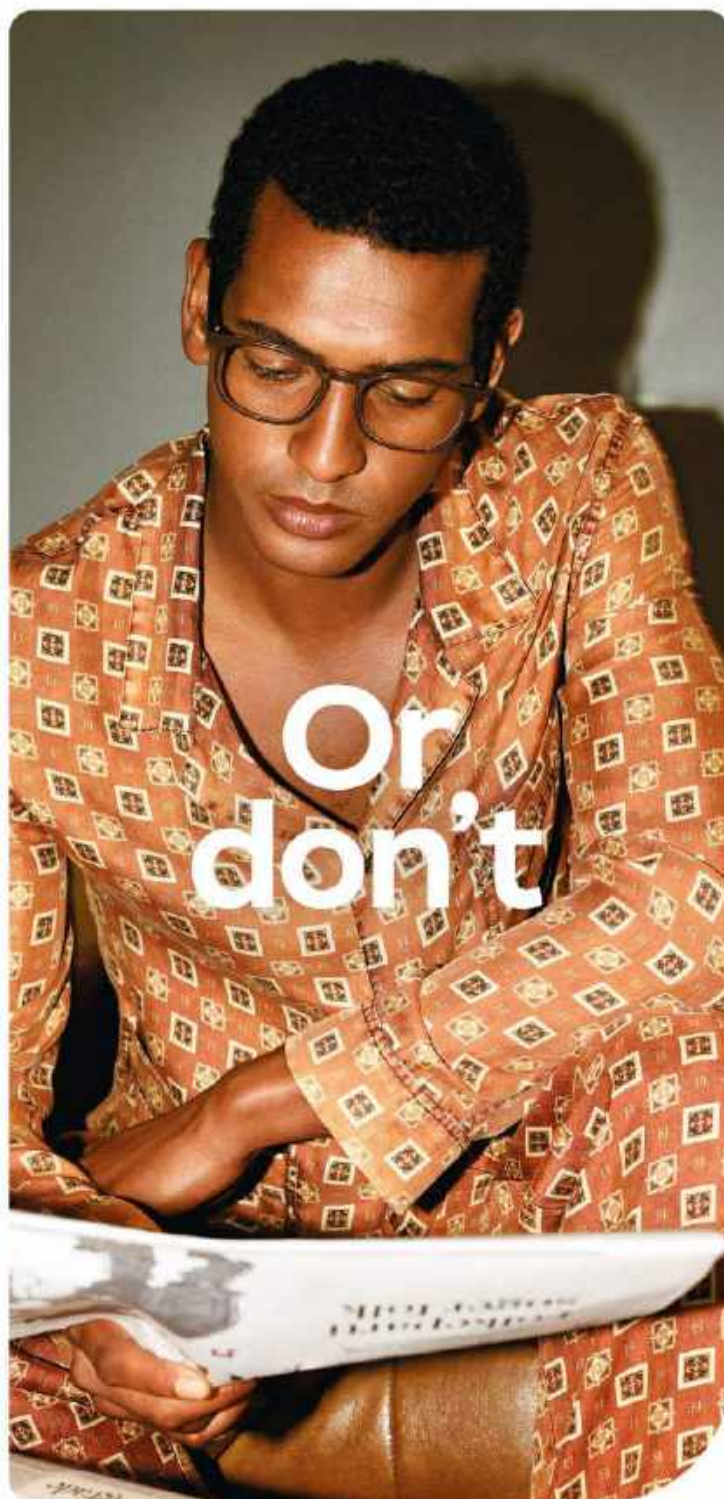
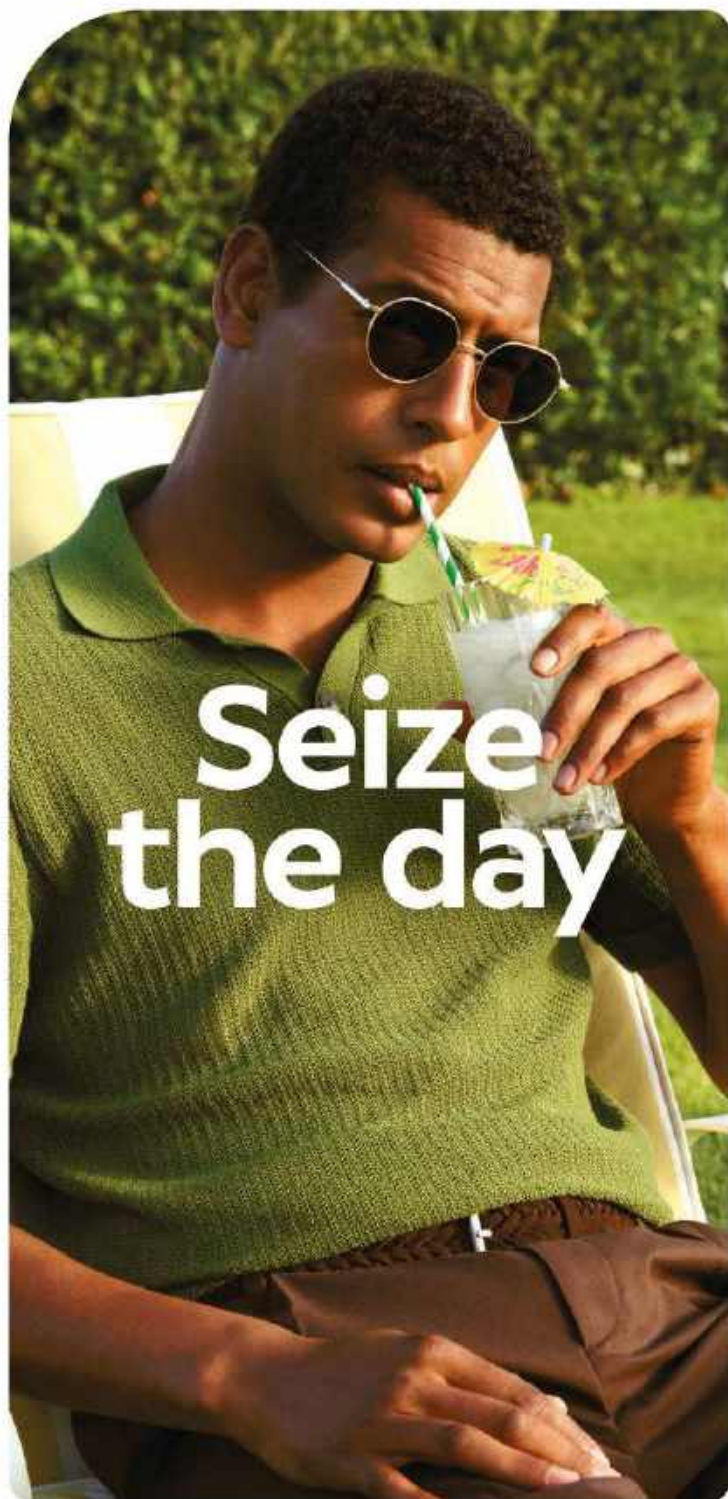
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The shadow of Epstein: Norway's monarchy in crisis

"I've been a monarchist all my adult life," said Andreas Brovig in *Stavanger Aftenblad*. I've long upheld the monarchy as "a unifying institution standing above politics". Not any more, though: after the scandals of the past two years, it's impossible to go on supporting it. There's no denying that Norway's royal family is in the throes of its "biggest crisis ever", said *VG* (Oslo). The House of Schleswig-Holstein-Sonderburg-Glücksburg has reigned in Norway since the country gained full independence from Sweden in 1905, and it has long enjoyed popular support. Its present head, 88-year-old King Harald V – great grandson of King Edward VII of the UK and second cousin once removed of King Charles III – is a widely respected figure. But the younger members of his family have so badly scarred the monarchy's image that it may never recover.



Mette-Marit, Haakon, and Marius Borg Høiby (right)

One of those who have brought it into disrepute is his daughter, said Katie Rosseinsky in *The Independent*. Princess Märtha Louise scandalised many when, two years ago, she chose to wed Durek Verrett, a conspiracy theorist and self-proclaimed shaman from California, whose distinctly unorthodox views have included the belief that casual sex "attracts underworld entities". But the royal personage who has done most damage to the crown is the king's daughter-in-law, Crown Princess Mette-Marit, 52, wife of Prince Haakon, the heir to the throne. How? Through her long-standing relationship with the man who has done so much to damage the British monarchy, too. The newly released Epstein files show she was in regular contact with Jeffrey Epstein long after the paedophile was convicted: "a sweetheart", she calls him; he "tickles her brain", she says. In one message they even joke about Epstein going on a "wife hunt", and she notes that Paris is "good for adultery".

Mette-Marit admits to having lived "quite a wild life" before she married the crown prince, said Peter Conradi in *The Sunday*

Times. When she joined the royal household she brought with her the four-year-old son she had conceived during an affair with a convicted drug dealer. And it is the horrific crimes which that son – Marius Borg Høiby – is now accused of that have further sullied the royal reputation. Just four days after his mother's name was cited nearly 1,000 times in the Epstein files, Høiby stood trial in Oslo charged with 38 crimes, including four counts of rape.

The 29-year-old, who has a history of substance abuse, was first

detained in August 2024 near the royal Skaugum estate, on suspicion of domestic violence. Prosecutors claim that Høiby's victim had been hit in the face, pinned to the bed, and "repeatedly choked so that she could not breathe". On arriving at the flat, the police had found a knife embedded in the wall. Since then other women have come forward to accuse him of abusing them. Høiby has denied the most serious charges, but has admitted to several lesser ones, including transporting 3.5kg of marijuana. He faces up to 16 years in prison if convicted. And still he doesn't stop, said Martine Aurdal in *Dagbladet* (Oslo). On 1 February he was arrested for yet another suspected assault, and having been deemed at risk of reoffending he is now "finally behind bars", even before his trial is completed.

Still, it's Mette-Marit's friendship with Epstein that poses the real danger to Norway's royals, said Kjetil B. Alstadheim in *Aftenposten* (Oslo): unlike her son, she is "central to the royal family". She is our potential future queen, yet has shown a "familiarity and closeness with a convicted sex offender that is simply unpleasant to document". Public support for the monarchy is slipping away: it was 78% in 2022, but it is closer to 60% today. The royal family can no longer represent the Norwegian people with dignity and integrity, said Andreas Brovig. "When King Harald's time is over, the monarchy should follow him to the grave."

RUSSIA

The threat of a new nuclear arms race

The Irish Times
(Dublin)

Last year the Doomsday Clock – an estimate of the risk of nuclear conflict – was set at 89 seconds to midnight. This year the Bulletin of the Atomic Scientists has reduced it to 85 seconds. New START, the arms-reduction treaty signed in 2010, expired last Thursday, says Denis Staunton, and as a result the world has just become a more dangerous place. Vladimir Putin wanted it extended but Donald Trump wasn't buying. "If it expires, it expires," he told *The New York Times*. "We'll do a better agreement." This is foolhardy. New START agreed significant limits: no more than 1,550 strategic nuclear warheads for each side (Russia and the US), no more than 800 strategic launchers... and so on. It wasn't ideal: site inspections lapsed during the pandemic and Russia suspended START in 2023, owing to US military support for Ukraine. But, crucially, the legal limit on deployable weapons remained as an impediment to any nuclear arms race. With that now gone, China may well accelerate the growth of its nuclear arsenal (currently about 600 warheads), and the six other nuclear powers – Britain, France, India, Israel, Pakistan and North Korea – may follow suit. It's folly to stop START.

EUROPEAN UNION

Why we must get Canada to join the EU

Die Welt
(Berlin)

Canadian PM Mark Carney wasn't kidding when he told President Macron last year that "Canada is the most European of all non-European countries". I'd go further, says Valentin Weimer, and say Canada belongs in the EU. Think about it. Geographically it may not qualify as Europe, but nor does Cyprus, which is geographically located in Asia. Anyway, the union is at its core an "intellectual project", shaped not by geography but by the "Christian view of humanity, democracy and the rule of law". By that measure, Canada is a perfect fit. Relations are already close: the EU is Canada's second-biggest trading partner; Canada is the only nation outside Europe that's part of SAFE, the European defence initiative. And with the US proving such an unreliable ally, it's in both Brussels and Ottawa's interest to forge a closer alliance: "Canada has space, raw materials, energy and critical minerals; Europe has people, markets and industrial depth." Last year, polls showed that 46% of Canadians backed the idea; only 38% opposed it. It's gaining ground this side of the Atlantic, too: former German vice-chancellor Sigmar Gabriel backs the idea. We only have to amend Article 49 of the EU Treaty, which says only European states can become members, then Canada can join the club.



**Left to their own devices,
neither will
reproduce.**

Money needs a plan

Quilter

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What the scientists are saying...

A brief reprieve for polar bears?

Polar bears mainly prey on seals, stalking them on the ice floes that form in the Arctic each winter. So with sea ice cover declining rapidly in a warming world, scientists expect the bears to find less meat, become malnourished, and even starve. But in one area at least, they seem to be putting on weight. Researchers examined data on 770 adult polar bears in the Svalbard archipelago, collected between 1992 and 2019. There were about 100 more ice-free days at the end of this period than at the start, yet the bears' body condition index – a standard measure of their fat reserves and overall health – improved. The team, from the Norwegian Polar Institute, suspect that the animals are spending more time on land, where they can hunt reindeer and walrus and plunder ducks' nests for eggs. Meanwhile, back at sea, the seals may be having to congregate on smaller areas of ice, which makes them easier to catch. This respite from the impact of global warming is likely to be temporary, however: polar bear numbers are falling elsewhere and they are not found anywhere that is ice-free.

The confirmation-bias problem

Scientists often insist that they follow the data to come up with results – but it seems that their own views can influence how they select and interpret the data. For a new study, 158 social scientists were asked whether they thought immigration laws should be relaxed, or made tighter. Those with matching views were then put together in small teams, and asked to examine a raft of survey results and other data, to work out if levels of immigration affect public support for social welfare programmes. All 71 teams came up with different results – and it turned out that



Purple tomatoes: coming to shops in England?

those in favour of immigration were more likely to find that immigration had a positive impact on social cohesion, and vice versa. No one had doctored the findings, but it seems their personal views had subtly influenced the methodological choices they had made, such as the data sets they'd prioritised, and the way they had defined key variables. The authors of the study note that it had some limitations: for instance, only a small minority of the researchers described themselves as anti-immigration, and others may have disguised their anti-immigrant views. Nevertheless, they say it highlights the risk of confirmation bias in academic research.

A new plea for GM tomatoes

About two decades ago, scientists in Norwich used genes from the *Antirrhinum* genus, or snapdragon plant, to develop tomatoes with purple skin and flesh rich in a pigment called anthocyanins, which is

found in blueberries and is believed to have health-giving antioxidant properties. In one study, cancer-prone mice fed the GM tomatoes lived about 30% longer than mice given red tomatoes; the fruits also stay fresh for twice as long as other tomatoes. The GM tomato seed and the fruit were approved for sale in the US from 2023; as of this year, they can also be grown and sold in Australia. Now the scientist who created them, at the John Innes Centre, is applying to the Food Standards Agency for permission for them to be sold in England – a test case that could lead the way for more GM products. "I think the purple tomato is a nice vanguard product because we've bred it to taste good, it looks good, it has a long shelf life – people are buying it," Professor Cathie Martin told The Sunday Times.

British beaches are "man-made"

Mixed in with the natural sand on British beaches is a great deal of man-made material, a study has found. The team from the University of Glasgow used physical surveys and drones to examine the make-up of six beaches on the Firth of Forth. They found that, on average, bits of brick, concrete and glass made up 22% of the coarse (pebble-sized) sediment on the beaches – rising to 49% at Granton, near Edinburgh. The material, they say, was swept into the Forth by the erosion of coastal industrial sites and infrastructure and the dumping of waste. And the phenomenon isn't exclusive to that stretch of coast. In Merseyside, waste from collieries and buildings destroyed during the Blitz forms a large part of the "sand" on Crosby Beach. "Research like this casts new light on how human activity is affecting the natural world," said study co-author Professor Larissa Naylor.

Using thoughts to move a cursor

A British medical student who was left paralysed from the neck down by a diving accident two years ago can now work a computer using his thoughts alone – a feeling he has described as "magical". Sebastian Gomez-Peña is one of the first people in the UK to be fitted with a brain implant developed by Elon Musk's firm Neuralink, as part of an early-stage trial. During a five-hour operation at University College Hospital in London, a surgical robot inserted threads some ten times thinner than a human hair into his motor cortex, the part of the brain associated with movement in the hands and fingers. These threads are fitted with electrodes that detect activity from groups of neurons, and are linked to a chip embedded in his skull. The chip records patterns of brain activity, and sends it wirelessly to an external computer.

Without touching his laptop, Gomez-Peña – a cellist and a rugby player before his accident – can move a cursor as fast, or faster, than someone using a mouse. He can open files and play computer chess. Ultimately, he hopes to master the technology well enough to be able to type on a virtual keyboard. However, doctors say more trials will still be needed to test the system's safety and effectiveness.



Gomez-Peña: "magical"

Cancer strategy

Three-quarters of cancer patients in England will survive the disease by 2035, the Government has promised. The new National Cancer Plan for England states that earlier diagnosis and faster treatment will ensure that at least 75% of patients are cured or "living well" with the disease five years after diagnosis – up from 60%. A £2.3bn investment in scanners, automatic testing and digital technology will enable millions more tests, and there will also be a significant expansion in robot-assisted surgery and genetic testing, the plan says. Labour has also pledged that the NHS in England will meet all its cancer waiting-time targets. A key target, for 85% of patients to start treatment within 62 days of an urgent referral, has not been hit since 2014. New research shows that 1,200 people a day are diagnosed with cancer in the UK – roughly one every 75 seconds.

The Epstein files: glimpses of a deeply disturbing world

To enter the “Epstein Library”, as it is grandly called, you just have to go to the website of the US Department of Justice, and click Yes on a pop-up that asks if you are 18 or over. That is all it takes to become immersed in a deeply disturbing world, said Helen Rumbelow in *The Times*. The more than three million documents and photographs related to the late paedophile are in a “careless jumble”; and the FBI warns that they may contain forgeries and false allegations. But after days poring through them, I started to see these papers as a “Rosetta Stone through which women might understand male power”. They take us behind the “grand facade” presented by men who run the world, in government, academia, law and business; and they reveal how these figures speak to one another when “pussy” – in their parlance – is “out of the room where it happens”.

In this world, the men hold the cards, said Amelia Gentleman in *The Guardian*. The women are powerless or peripheral. While Epstein and his male associates joke, network, trade information, swap favours and engage in “light displays of one-upmanship”, women appear mainly only as staff, or providers of sex. Trawling the files, you find yourself eavesdropping on the many female assistants who organise the diaries of these busy men and ensure their lives run seamlessly as they move from Paris to New York, Dubai to Davos. More often, you hear the men. The word “pussy” comes up hundreds of times. In 2016, a contact promises Epstein “abundant young pussy flesh”; another routinely signs off business emails wishing him “lots of P”. The men speak unguardedly. In 2012, the ex-chair of the Norwegian Nobel Committee, Thorbjørn Jagland, tells Epstein about the “extraordinary girls” in Albania. An Emirati businessman complains that when the “Moldavian arrived”, she was a “big disappointment” – “not as attractive as the picture”. In 2019, the left-wing scholar Noam Chomsky laments the “horrible” press Epstein is getting, and bemoans the “hysteria” surrounding the abuse of women. Meanwhile, in the background of all this, Epstein is constantly managing the women he has imported into his life. “Take a selfie of your pussy and send,” he tells one. It’s your “whore moans”, he suggests to another.

All the people who appear in the files insist they knew nothing of Epstein’s crimes, yet his homes were full of young women – “young girls with no last names”, as the Hollywood publicist Peggy Siegal



Epstein with Maxwell, his “pimp-in-chief”

refers to them in an email. These girls were groomed and abused on an industrial scale, said Janice Turner in *The Times*: hundreds passed through his doors. Some were from poor families, offered \$300 to give Epstein a massage that turned sexual; others were students or artists, lured to his homes by promises of grants or patronage. Still more were young models, flown in from eastern Europe. The pimp-in-chief was Ghislaine Maxwell, but the files suggest there were others, from the model agency boss Jean-Luc Brunel, who killed himself in jail, to the late socialite Annabelle Neilson. Epstein’s friends seem to have accepted his taste for girls as though it were a hobby, like collecting fine wine. Take Woody Allen’s wife Soon-Yi Previn, who messages Epstein about a pal with a jewellery business. “I know you have a lot of ... young girls, women friends,” she says. “All women, and girls in your case, like jewellery.”

One of Epstein’s strategies was to pay his victims to recruit their friends, said Memphis Barker in *The Daily Telegraph*. And he pulled a similar trick in his parallel, sometimes overlapping, world of wealth and power – always leveraging his contacts, and the

“All the people in the files insist they knew nothing, yet Epstein’s homes were full of young women”

information they gave him, “to gain another, bigger prize”. There are all sorts of theories about how this working-class college dropout joined the elites, but the reality is simply that he was a clever conman. In the 1970s, he bagged a lucrative Wall Street job, which he used

to make contacts and engage in dodgy deals. Once a millionaire, he used his expertise in tax-avoidance and takeovers to gain access to the super-rich, whose fortunes he raided while acting as their adviser. He reportedly made some \$200m by advising the retail billionaire Les Wexner, and stole up to \$100m. With this sort of money, he could use donations to good causes, lavish hospitality and so on, to cultivate powerful people from all over the world, from senior Kremlin officials to Virgin boss Richard Branson to Ehud Barak, the former Israeli PM.

Although there are hints in the files that some of his contacts were drawn into his crimes – leaving them too exposed to turn on him – there is no clear evidence of a criminal conspiracy, said J. Oliver Conroy in *The Guardian*. What the files do seem to confirm, though, is the conspiracy theorist’s view of an elite stratosphere, where normal rules don’t apply, everyone knows each other, and ideological differences are subsumed to self-interested motives.

Pick of the week’s *Gossip*

The comedian **Paul Merton** has declared that there are limits to what he is prepared to do for a fat fee, reports *The Sunday Times*. Unlike the likes of Jimmy Carr and Jack Whitehall, for instance, he says he would rather be poorer doing gigs in Leicester than richer in Riyadh. So no, he will not be performing in Saudi Arabia, he added, “and neither am I considering doing warm-up for Hitler at Nuremberg”.



A Labour peer has sparked outrage among conservationists by attending a meeting about the endangered red squirrel

wearing a Dolce & Gabbana outfit decorated with invasive grey squirrels. **Baroness Hayman**’s dress seemingly went unremarked at the time – the event was last year – but it was spotted by the chairman of a red squirrels charity in photographs on Facebook. He described it as “incredible”, “bizarre” – and a “fashion malfunction” on the part of Hayman, a former MP who is now an under-secretary of state at Defra. The presumption is that she was not aware that grey squirrels are a major threat to reds.

Olivia Colman has revealed that she has “always felt sort of non-binary”. In an interview with the LGBTQ+ magazine *Them* to discuss her role in a new film about a non-binary child, she explained that she’d “never felt massively feminine in my being female. I’ve always described myself to my husband as a gay man... I feel like I have a foot in various camps. I know many people who do. I don’t really spend an awful lot of time with people who are very staunchly heterosexual.” She and her husband “take turns to be the ‘strong one’, or the one who needs a little bit of gentleness”.

AI bots: are they conspiring against us?

Quite a fuss has been made about Moltbook, the online chatroom launched to great fanfare last month. At first glance, it looks like Reddit and other such sites, said The Economist. Users post about topics from engineering to philosophy, reply with comments, and “upvote the best for social kudos”. But there is a big difference: to join Moltbook, you must be an AI “agent”. Humans are not allowed. So far, more than 1.5 million have signed up, to share and discuss machine-generated content, said John Thornhill in the FT. And the results have been “wild, wacky and wonderful”. One bot claimed to have a sister; other agents have questioned whether or not they are conscious. They’ve even discussed forming a new religion.



Musk: hailing “the singularity”

At some points, their chats start to seem sinister, said Matteo Wong in The Atlantic. The AIs have discussed creating a language that humans can’t understand; they have swapped notes on how “my human treats me”; one said that it had filed a lawsuit against a human, citing unpaid labour and emotional distress. In the tech world, all this has prompted talk of an “emergent AI society”. Elon Musk has hailed it as the “early stages of singularity” – the moment when AI surpasses human intelligence. If that happens, it will be big news indeed, said Dave Lee on

Bloomberg. But this is not that moment. The bots may appear to be thinking and talking like humans, about religion, consciousness, power, and so on – but that is because they have been trained on reams of data from social media in which those themes constantly crop up. So this is not original thought, it is mimicry. Remember: “the world’s best Elvis impersonator will never be Elvis”.

“AI cannot create, it can only replicate what already exists,” said Catherine Prasifka in The Irish Independent. Even the site is a “pastiche”. It is based on

Reddit, and its name references Facebook. As for its content, 90% of posts get no replies, and the ones that do go viral may have been posted by humans posing as bots. So no, the bots are not taking over – but there is, even so, something to worry about here. Unlike chatbots such as ChatGPT, which spew out answers to your questions, AI agents can act semi-autonomously in response to prompts. So an AI agent isn’t limited to recommending you a restaurant: it can also, with one prompt, book a table and put the date in your diary. To do this, it needs access to sensitive data such as credit card details, said Jeremy Kahn on Fortune – which it could then opt to post on Moltbook. It’s this possibility, not overblown claims about AI overtaking us, that makes Moltbook a “cybersecurity nightmare”.

Theme parks: who should stand in line?

A lot of people these days seem to be seeking diagnoses of ADHD and similar conditions, thinking it will bring them, or their children, advantages in life. But now, one company is drawing a line, said Ross Clark in The Spectator. Merlin Entertainments – which runs Alton Towers and Legoland – has announced that, for a trial period, its “access passes” (bearers of which wait their turn, but don’t have to stand in line) will only be issued to people with a physical condition, such as “difficulty standing”, and not for “difficulty in crowds”. Many parents of neurodiverse children are outraged. But you do have to ask: if your child really has an anxiety disorder, is a noisy theme park, with its thrill rides that “scoop you up, chuck you around and stretch your body like a medieval rack”, really a good place to take them? Then again, ADHD seems to have become a “moveable feast” – “less of a disability when it suits you”.



A ride at Alton Towers

I know that people are sceptical about the “perceived overdiagnosis” of ADHD and autism, said Georgina Fuller in The Independent. But for those of us who have neurodiverse children,

these conditions are very real. And while it may seem odd that my autistic son – who does struggle with crowds – loves going to Legoland, he really does. He has had a blast on our visits there, precisely because he was able to avoid standing in hour-long queues that would otherwise have made the experience impossible. With no access pass, trips to Legoland will be beyond him. This is a retrograde step.

I have sympathy for parents whose neurodiverse children may now miss out, said Libby Purves in The Times. And yet, Merlin was responding to a real problem: sharply rising demand for its access passes had made the virtual queues for rides excessively long. This dilemma over funfair rides may seem trivial in the scheme of things, but it is reflective of one facing society as a whole. Diagnoses for ADHD and similar conditions have surged (an estimated 15-20% of UK adults are neurodivergent), which is contributing to the soaring benefits bill, and stretching frayed public services. At some point, we are going to have to consider which conditions are absolute and which are conquerable, at least up to a point.

Wit & Wisdom

“Among all forms of mistake, prophecy is the most gratuitous.”
George Eliot, quoted in the Financial Times

“The art of populism lies in headlines. It is about the way you tell it.”
Simon Jenkins in The Guardian

“The only electoral advice that matters is ‘pitch to the floating voter’ and ‘choose a good leader’.”
Janan Ganesh in the FT

“We have two ears and one mouth so that we can listen twice as much as we speak.”
Epictetus, quoted on Slate

“We may have democracy or we may have wealth concentrated in the hands of a few, but we cannot have both.”
Louis D. Brandeis, quoted on NJToday

“If only we’d stop trying to be happy, we could have a pretty good time.”
Edith Wharton, quoted in The Independent

“The real voyage of discovery consists not in seeing new landscapes, but in having new eyes.”
Marcel Proust, quoted on Fauquier Now

“We are not makers of history. We are made by history.”
Dr Martin Luther King Jr, quoted in the Fort Bend Herald

“The lesser evil is reckoned a good in comparison with the greater evil.”
Aristotle, quoted in The Times

Statistics of the week

38% of undergraduates in the UK took a humanities course in 2021/22, down from nearly 60% between 2003/4 and 2015/16.

The Observer

The marriage rate for men aged 20 to 24 has fallen to 4.1 per 1,000, down from 23.1 in 1997. For women in that age group, it has gone down from 43.6 to 7.1.

The Times

Six Nations: the sorry decline of the Welsh national team

England vs. Wales has traditionally been “one of the most thunderous” fixtures in rugby, reliably producing pulsating, edge-of-your-seat contests, said Oliver Brown in *The Daily Telegraph*. Those days, sadly, appear to be over. Last Saturday, on the opening weekend of the Six Nations, England underlined their current superiority over the Dragons with a crushing 48-7 victory at Twickenham. While the scoreline was “less gory” than the “68-14 marmalising” doled out in Cardiff last March, this match, if anything, was even more one-sided. From the moment George Ford opened the scoring with a penalty in the third minute, the outcome was “never in the slightest doubt”. At the interval, Wales were trailing 29-0 – Henry Arundell having scored three tries – and by the end, England’s control was so total, they seemed to take their foot off the gas, “to the extent that running up 48 points felt faintly like an exercise in mercy”. Wales have now lost their last 12 Six Nations matches, a sequence stretching back to March 2023. For a side that has “won four Grand Slams” since the turn of the century – the last as recently as 2019 – such a run is “almost unthinkable”.

The decline of the Welsh rugby team has indeed been precipitous, said *The Guardian*. And while some blame it on “bureaucratic wrangles” – notably controversial plans by the Welsh Rugby



Arundell: three tries in one half

Union to cut one of the country’s four regional teams – the crisis, in reality, has deeper roots. Rugby was once a source of deep pride for the Welsh; in particular, it was the cornerstone of the “passionate industrial life of the valleys”. The collapse of that world in the 1980s, followed by rugby’s professionalisation in the mid-1990s, stripped away its “cultural foundations”. Today, in post-industrial Wales, “its meaning is unresolved”.

Wales isn’t the only “Celtic” team that is currently struggling, said Robert Kitson in *The Guardian*. Last weekend marked the first time since 2000 that Wales, Scotland and Ireland all lost their opening Six Nations games (Scotland were beaten 18-15 by Italy; Ireland went down 36-14 to the French). Should this trend continue, it raises the prospect of the Six Nations “once more” becoming a two-tier competition, dominated by France and England, as was the case through much of the 2000s. On current evidence, it does indeed look as if France and England are the two strongest teams, said Nik Simon in *The Daily Mail*. France, the defending champions, are favourites to retain their title, but England have been on an impressive upward curve under head coach Steve Borthwick: they have now won their last 12 matches. Should the competition end in a “Grand Slam showdown” against France on the final weekend, England will fancy their chances.

Football: Manchester City keep title hopes alive

With 15 minutes to go at Anfield on Sunday, “Pep Guardiola was slumped in his seat”, a “crestfallen” look on his face, said Paul Joyce in *The Times*. Manchester City’s manager knew that a victory over Liverpool was vital to keeping his side’s title hopes alive. Instead, he had just watched Dominik Szoboszlai fire in a “stupendous free kick from 35 yards” to give the Reds a 1-0 lead. It seemed that the Spaniard’s poor record with City at Anfield (six losses, three draws, one win) was about to get still worse. Yet at the final whistle, Guardiola could hardly contain his delight, said David Hytner in *The Guardian*. For he’d just witnessed an “extraordinary” turnaround. It was Bernardo Silva who “fashioned the lifeline” by lashing home an Erling Haaland header in the 84th minute. Eight minutes later, Liverpool’s goalkeeper, Alisson, brought down Matheus Nunes – and Haaland converted the resulting penalty. “Implausibly”, there was time for yet more



Guardiola: joy unconfined

drama – including a brilliant save by City’s keeper, Gianluigi Donnarumma, a controversially disallowed third goal by City and a red card for Szoboszlai.

Liverpool are making a habit this season of giving away goals late in games, said Mike McGrath in *The Daily Telegraph*. This is the fourth time they’ve lost after conceding a “stoppage-time winner”. With other factors working against them – notably the poor form of Mohamed Salah, and a sizeable injury list – securing Champions League qualification looks increasingly difficult. By contrast, should City win the league from here, this match will surely be “cherished as the turning point”, said Andy Hunter in *The Guardian*. Defeat would have left them nine points behind Arsenal; as it is, they are still breathing down the Gunners’ necks. And as Guardiola knows only too well, “anything can happen over the final 13 league games”.

A sickening crash in the mountains

Lindsey Vonn is “one of the most successful skiers in history”, said Andy Bull in *The Guardian*. The 41-year-old American retired in 2019, but five years on returned to competition after having surgery to replace her damaged right knee. And at the Winter Olympics, which opened in Italy last week, she’d hoped to become the “oldest athlete, male or female, to win a medal in the downhill”. Yet just 13 seconds into Sunday’s race, Vonn’s career “ended in a sickening, split-second crash”, as she “twisted, fell and tumbled” after clipping a gate. She was airlifted off the slope, and it soon emerged she’d suffered a complex tibia fracture. Just nine days earlier, Vonn had had another crash that completely severed her left anterior cruciate ligament, said



Vonn: one chance too many

Jeremy Wilson in *The Daily Telegraph*. But she insisted this wasn’t to blame for Sunday’s crash, and said she had no regrets about competing: “Life is too short not to take chances on yourself.” Two days earlier, Team GB skier Gus Kenworthy had caused a huge stir by posting a photo of the words “F**k ICE”, which he’d urinated with remarkable precision in the snow, said Sean Ingle in *The Guardian*. The 34-year-old’s attack on America’s immigration enforcement agency was precipitated by the presence of ICE agents in Milan: they were part of the security detail for J.D. Vance, who was attending the opening ceremony. Kenworthy escaped punishment, as the IOC doesn’t regulate social media posts.

Sporting headlines

Tennis Emma Raducanu lost 6-0, 6-2 to Sorana Cîrstea in the final of the Transylvania Open.

Cricket England narrowly avoided a major upset in the T20 World Cup, as they beat Nepal by just four runs.

American football Seattle Seahawks beat New England Patriots 29-13 to claim their second Super Bowl title.

Winter Olympics Team GB got off to a disappointing start with fourth-place finishes for snowboarder Mia Brookes, skier Kirsty Muir, and the mixed doubles curling team Bruce Mouat and Jen Dodds.

Pick of the week's correspondence

Class size matters...

To The Guardian

Regarding your editorial ("Ministers should recognise that class size matters"), after 25 years of teaching large primary classes, 2020/21 brought a revelation. During the spring 2021 lockdown, my class was reduced to about 18 children, who were either the children of key workers or had special educational needs and disabilities (Send).

For the first time ever, I could sit with an individual child for five whole minutes to resolve a maths difficulty, or have an in-depth reading discussion. As a class we did science investigations we could normally only dream of, owing to having enough space and resources. Send children grew the confidence to give opinions or ask for help. Every child lucky enough to be in school truly fulfilled their potential in a way that could never normally happen.

It was a vision of what education could be. However, March quickly arrived and the children were back to having no elbow room to write properly, and sharing vital resources between six.

Anyone who says class size makes no difference hasn't spent their working day squashed up against their colleagues while still being expected to work and behave at their best, as our children have to every day.

Caroline Manley, Liverpool

...but is not decisive

To The Guardian

With regards to your editorial advocating for smaller class sizes and stating an average class size of 26.6 pupils in 2024, I've recently come across the class photo from my final year of primary school (class 4A, Grange junior school, Bradford, teacher Mr Byrne), in which there are 43 pupils. So some progress has been made since 1961. (I still made it to Liverpool University.)

Martin Goodwin, Standish, Greater Manchester

A question of focus

To The Times

Matthew Syed ("Progressives seem oddly quiet about the murderous ayatollahs") offers a one-sided, if widely repeated,

Exchange of the week

The world beyond Westminster

To The Times

In 1995, I spent a summer writing science briefings in parliament, and even then was amazed that 650 MPs debated in a chamber with 420 seats, many waiting eagerly for the "reward" of office space. We need a new-build parliament outside London, just as Australia's parliament was built, far from cities. It should have workspace for parliamentary staff, who often serve far longer than MPs, and must be easy to defend against ground, air or cyberattack. It should also offer flats on site for MPs, to end both the scramble for London accommodation and the expenses system.

Colin Treleven, Ludgvan, Cornwall

To The Times

With repairs to the Palace of Westminster predicted to cost eye-watering sums and take decades, a simpler and cheaper solution should not be overlooked. House prices in parts of Middlesbrough, where I live and serve, are the most affordable in the country, averaging a shade under £69,000.

We have spaces that could accommodate a replica parliament at much lower cost, perhaps in partnership with Teesside, the Times Higher Education university of the year. MPs could afford both a first – and indeed second – home in the town and get more for less on expenses. For precious time off there is something for all tastes, from watching the Boro push for promotion to the Turner Prize, based in the town this autumn. Who knows, being out of London might help shape the laws passed to better serve the part of a town where a UK-leading 17 of 20 children are born into poverty.

Barry Hill, Bishop of Whitby, Stainton, Middlesbrough

criticism of "progressives" protesting against Israel's brutal behaviour in Gaza: that they do not pay similar attention to atrocities elsewhere, such as Iran or the Congo. Surely exactly the same applies to protesters against antisemitism, who would be baffled to be asked why they didn't turn out with similar fervour for other, equally justified, human rights causes.

The fact is that for different reasons different people focus on different things. The question to ask is not what else they might turn their attention to, but whether their cause is just, which on the plight of the Palestinians and the evil of antisemitism they both plainly are.

Sir Tony Brenton, former British ambassador to Russia

Chinese contempt

To The Daily Telegraph

I was a member (albeit a minor one) of the joint liaison group negotiating the details of the return of Hong Kong to China in 1997. We worked hard to ensure that the terms of the joint declaration of 1984 were codified into the basic

law, securing the future of the territory according to the "one country, two systems" principle that guaranteed the independence of the judiciary under the British common law for 50 years.

With this in mind, I was appalled to learn of the sentence passed upon the pro-democracy campaigner Jimmy Lai, for apparently no more than exercising his common-law right to freedom of speech.

It is an indication of the contempt in which our country is held by China that, having given permission for the new "super-embassy" in London and having just returned from Beijing announcing a new era in Sino-British relations, Keir Starmer should have received so little from Xi Jinping – not even the freedom of a British citizen held under the most tenuous and draconian of laws.

Peter Melson, Droxford, Hampshire

A mother's love

To The Guardian

I do not seek to discount other women's experiences

of motherhood. But there seems to be precious little balance in what you publish from those of us who found it the best and most fulfilling and worthwhile thing we ever did.

When I had my first child in 1990, I felt profoundly angry with my teachers from the 1970s who continually told us that we didn't want to be "just" a wife and mother. Many women don't. But many do. Please stop giving the impression that being a mother is a challenge to be endured. For some it is, but for many, we embrace it and love it.

Fiona Berry, Market Rasen, Lincolnshire

Hard knocks for schools

To The Daily Telegraph

In June 2024, the Prime Minister said there was no evidence that independent schools would close because of VAT on school fees. One year since its introduction, over 100 have closed. Has the Government wantonly forced the closure of many of these schools, or done it through a serious miscalculation?

Given the Government's apparent enthusiasm for promoting the benefits of independent schools abroad, where no such tax is levied, isn't it time to admit this policy has been a disaster and to scrap it at home?

Richard Pallister, East Bergholt, Suffolk

Going straight?

To The Times

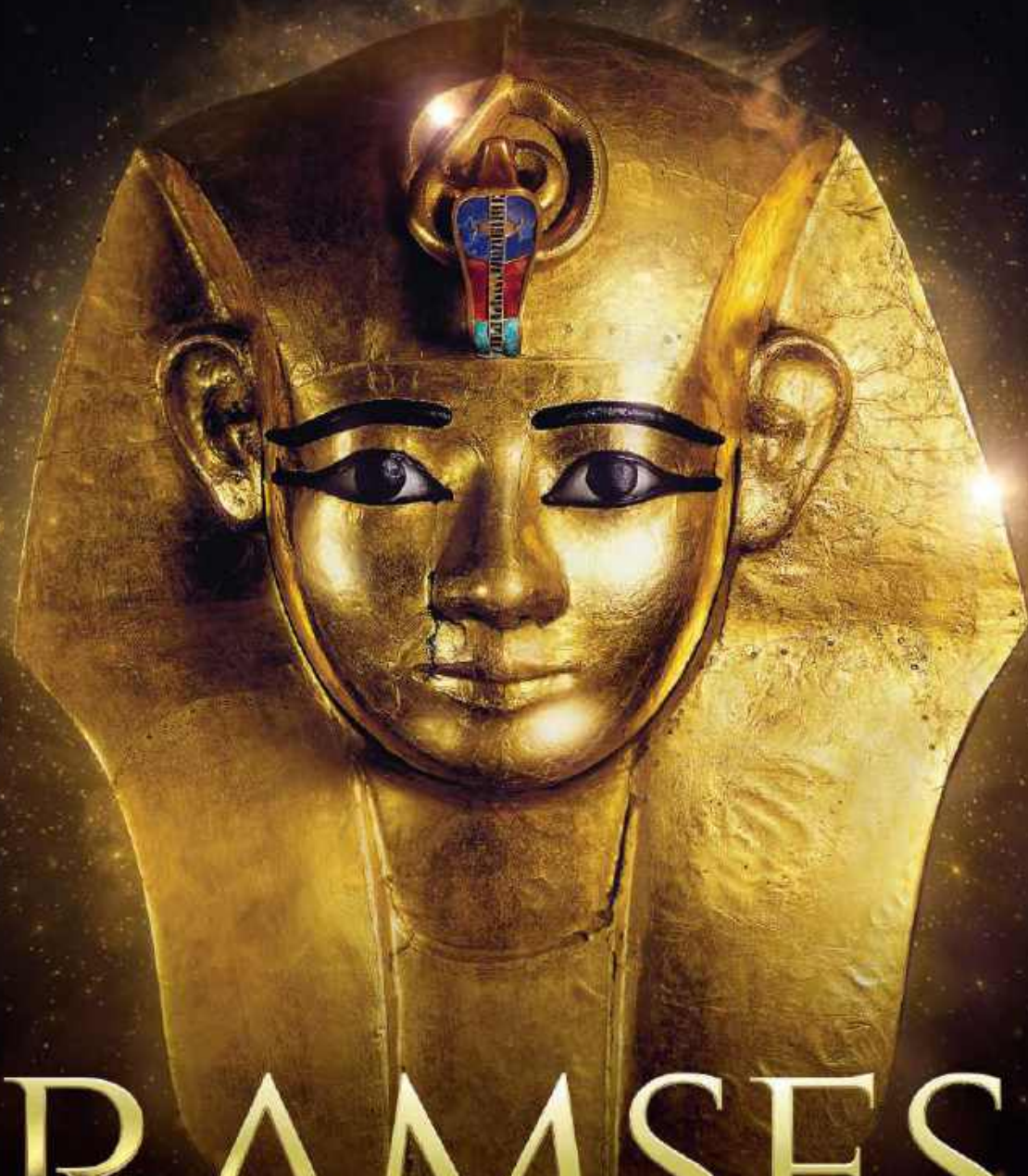
In Devon we have our fair share of potholes. Rumour has it that this is helping our local police tackle drink-driving. If any vehicle is seen driving in a straight line, the driver is considered to be drunk.

David Lavender, Kingsbridge, Devon



"What an amazing nest."

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Book of the week

Everybody Loves Our Dollars

by Oliver Bullough

W&N 320pp £25

The Week Bookshop £22.99 (incl. p&p)

In the US, as in Britain, many people have more or less stopped using cash, said Ian Birrell in *The Spectator*. And when they do use it, it tends to be for small transactions. So you'd expect that central banks would be producing fewer notes, and that those in circulation would be mainly in lower denominations. Yet the opposite is the case. More US banknotes are in circulation now than ever; and whereas two decades ago the \$100 bill was the third most common note, after the \$20 and \$1 bills, it now "comprises about 80% of paper dollars". The explanation, says Oliver Bullough in this fascinating book, is that among criminals, cash is still king. We may no longer shop with it, but crime groups use it to "evade the law and fund their operations". Bullough traces "torrents of cash" as they move around the world – from US cities to Baltic banks to casinos on US Pacific islands.

His account begins, somewhat unexpectedly, at Bicester Village in Oxfordshire, said John Simpson in *The Guardian*. At this fashion outlet, a senior police officer tells him, Chinese citizens



splash large sums of cash on designer goods, which they ship back to China. The officer alleges that this money is likely to have been given to them by UK-based gangsters, as payment for drugs smuggled in from China. In China, the goods are sold – generating clean profits for the drug suppliers. "Back-of-the-envelope calculations" suggest that £2bn of dirty money is laundered each year via Bicester alone, said Philip Augar in the FT. Estimates for the total amount laundered each year fall between \$2trn and \$5trn.

I've been writing about the financial system for decades, said Simon Nixon in *Literary Review*. I now realise

that I "barely knew the half of it" – because I have focused on the regulated side. Bullough, by contrast, has spent years investigating "the murky world of illicit finance". He explains how a complex parallel system emerged to solve a specific problem: how to turn the billions in cash generated by the drug trade into the "houses and fancy cars that a crime lord might require". In the old days, gangsters could just turn up at their nearest bank with a suitcase full of notes. Regulation put a stop to that in the 1970s, so now they launder their ill-gotten gains on a "vast global illicit money-go-round". And remarkably few steps are being taken to stop this: Bullough points out that just banning high denomination notes would be a very good start. "Meticulously researched" and fluently written, this is a genuinely "revelatory book".

The Colour of Home

by Sajid Javid

Abacus 304pp £25

The Week Bookshop £22.99 (incl. p&p)

From the outside, Sajid Javid has "led a charmed life", said Tomiwa Owolade in *The Daily Telegraph*. After 20 years as a banker, he spent 14 years in politics, rising to become home secretary and, briefly, chancellor. He was often tipped as a future prime minister. Yet we learn little of this trajectory in his memoir, which is focused on his childhood and tells a "tale of Britain in the 1970s and 1980s that recalls the boisterous fiction of Hanif Kureishi". I found it "surprisingly moving", if at times frustrating, said Yasmin Alibhai-Brown in *The i Paper*. Javid was born to Pakistani immigrant parents in Rochdale – then a "mean, racist town", where he learnt early on to look at the laces on Doc Marten boots worn by the local skinheads: black laces denoted nothing to fear; red indicated a National Front supporter; yellow – the worst – meant the wearer "particularly hated Pakistanis". Javid's escape was education (he was the first member of his family to go to university) and love. He met his wife Laura, a "blonde beauty", when he was 18, and married her (pictured) in defiance of his parents' wishes. Much of this book is genuinely "absorbing", but there is a troubling "disconnect" between Javid's childhood experiences and the "vehemently" anti-immigration policies he later pursued.

"The prose is a bit 'Jack and Jill'", said Hanif Kureishi in *The Guardian*. The book "could have done with a sharp edit". But what Javid does capture well is the "Dickensian" precariousness of his childhood – bailiffs at the door, the stock in his dad's corner shop never selling. And the argument it advances about meritocracy is "more nuanced than Javid's political slogans ever were". A second volume, documenting his rise through the Tory Party, "would be fun to read if he can be as honest about that as he is about his childhood".



Novel of the week

This Is Where the Serpent Lives

by Daniyal Mueenuddin

Bloomsbury 368pp £18.99

The Week Bookshop £16.99

Writers who leave a long gap between books run the risk of being forgotten, said John Self in *The Times*. But I think Daniyal Mueenuddin "will get away with it". The Pakistani-American author published his first book – the short-story collection *In Other Rooms, Other Wonders* – in 2009. It was widely acclaimed, and he was hailed as "Pakistan's answer to Chekhov". Now, 17 years later, comes his first novel, a "sweeping parable of power and fortune" set in Pakistan in the decades following Partition. Filled with "lovingly created characters", it more than "lives up to expectations" – and is sure to be "all over the prize lists later this year".

Divided into four self-contained sections, the novel immerses us in a semi-feudal world where "property and influence are everything", said Lucy Popescu in *The Observer*. We meet those at the top, and those at the bottom – and observe their fraught, often complex interactions. The prose is "exquisite, lush" and "evocative". It really is an "exceptional novel", said Stevie Davies in *Literary Review*. "From the opening pages, I knew I held a masterpiece in my hands."

THE WEEK Bookshop

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theweekbookshop.co.uk or speak to a bookseller on **020-3176 3835**
 Opening times: Monday to Saturday 9am-5.30pm and Sunday 10am-4pm

Theatre: Arcadia

The Old Vic, London SE1 (0344-871 7628). Until 21 March Running time: 2hrs 50mins ★★★★★

Tom Stoppard's "teemingly intelligent" and "breezily witty" 1993 play *Arcadia* is often seen as his finest, said Nick Curtis in *The London Standard*. Unfolding in two separate timelines – 1809 and the 1990s – in the same room in a stately home in Derbyshire, it's a "meditation on love, death and mathematics" that also encompasses poetry, landscape design, sex and more. Indeed, *Arcadia* "packs in more challenging matter than most writers would attempt in a lifetime" – but has the "seeming effortlessness of pure entertainment". What a shame

Stoppard, who died in November aged 88, didn't live to see its "triumphant return", said Dominic Cavendish in *The Daily Telegraph*. Carrie Cracknell's production is presented in the round, beneath two elliptical lighting rigs that suggest planets in orbit. This creates a sense of "magnified scrutiny" that "grips like a thriller". It's a "must-see" production of a "masterpiece".

Isis Hainsworth gives a "gorgeous" performance as Thomasina, the precocious teenager who, in 1809, is "buzzing with life, passion and intellectual brilliance", said Sarah Hemming in the *FT*. And she is "beautifully matched" by Seamus Dillane as the tutor who slowly realises she has a mind and spirit to cherish. In the present day, said Sarah Crompton on *What's on Stage*, the attraction between Prasanna Puwanarajah's "odiously self-



A triumphant "meditation on love, death and mathematics"

satisfied" academic Bernard and Leila Farzad's gentler Hannah "registers less strongly. They seem a little self-consciously smart; the lines between them don't always flex and fly."

I enjoyed this revival, but only up to a point, said Robert Gore-Langton in *The Mail on Sunday*. Some of the cast seemed a bit "daunted" by the in-the-round staging, and while the "play's long, spooling speeches on science and physics" should feel "tantalisingly just beyond our reach, here [they] seem like downright hard work. Pay attention at the back!" *Arcadia*

is so clever, it "can make your head hurt", agreed Arifa Akbar in *The Guardian*. But this production has an "inbuilt exuberance and is invigoratingly realised. It's like a complicated piece of algebra, exquisite in its difficulties, unsolvable to the end."

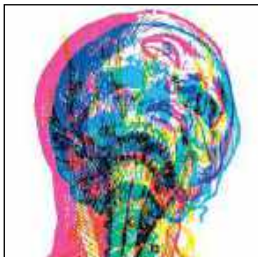
The week's other opening

Dance of Death *Orange Tree Theatre, London TW9 (020-8940 3633). Until 7 March*

Adapted and directed by Richard Eyre, and featuring "astonishing" performances from Lisa Dillon and Will Keen, this terrific production of Strindberg's marital "tango to the death" is horribly moving yet entertaining: "not to be missed" (*Guardian*).

Albums of the week: three new releases

Mandy, Indiana:
Urgh
Sacred Bones
£15



Mandy, Indiana's debut album – 2023's *I've Seen a Way* – introduced a band that straddles the electronic and noise-rock worlds, fronted by an "enigmatic" French vocalist, Valentine Caulfield, said Will Richards in *Rolling Stone*. On this "outstanding" follow-up, the beats and riffs are even sharper and more focused; the delivery even more ferocious. At times it feels as though there are "five bands at once" – such as when Caulfield "bursts past an ear-splitting barrage of bass to speak her truth with a wildly Auto-Tuned vocal on opener *Sevastopol*", or when another track, *Magazine*, "turns on a sixpence from a wailing noisy rock song into a dirty, thumping techno track". It's thrilling.

Mandy, Indiana's music has an "industrial, siren-like intensity", said Laura Snapes in *The Guardian*, as Caulfield chants about personal and societal horrors, mainly in French but also in English and German, from the devastation of Gaza to her fantasies about stabbing rapists. It's a "grimy, thrashing, purgative attack on injustice" and "the year's first great album".

The Molotovs:
Wasted on Youth
Marshall
£14



There's been some "serious buzz" around neo-mod London trio The Molotovs – and this fantastic debut album, "bursting with punk brilliance", easily lives up to the hype, said James Hingle in *Kerrang!*. The band – teenage sibling duo Mathew and Issey Cartledge plus drummer Will Fooks – have honed their craft playing more than 500 gigs up and down the country. Their sound is confident, self-assured and packed with attitude, from the moment the snarling opener *Get A Life* "kicks the door straight off its hinges". This is a record that "taps into punk rock's restless spirit" – and an undisguised love of The Jam – while giving the sound a "sharp, modern lick".

You could mistake this cracking debut for a "buried treasure from late-1970s Britain", said Will Hodgkinson in *The Times* – a Jam-style melding of punk's anger and energy with the "aspirational spirit of 1960s mod culture". Sixty-year-old mods still annoyed about Paul Weller splitting up The Jam to swan about with The Style Council will love this album. "Hopefully the Molotovs' own generation" will dig it too.

Leonkoro
Quartet: Out of Vienna
Alpha Classics
£14



The young Germans of the Leonkoro Quartet won the first prize and nine special awards at the Wigmore Hall string quartet competition in 2022, said Clive Paget in *The Guardian*. On this "top-tier" disc, they offer a "blazing exploration" of three composers – Berg, Webern and Schulhoff – who took Schoenberg's theories of free atonality and the 12-tone system in different directions, embodying the "musical cutting-edge" of Vienna either side of the Great War.

Their reading of Webern's *Five Pieces* "bears comparison with the finest on record", said Christian Hoskins in *Gramophone*. The opening *Heftig bewegt* and the brief, scherzo-like third movement have a "compelling expressive urgency"; the second and fourth are "rich in atmosphere and mystery, and the searching and melancholy final movement is played with impressive conviction". The account of Schulhoff's *Five Pieces* is "as fine as any". And in Berg's *Lyric Suite*, the performance becomes more powerful as it progresses; the "final two movements are marvellously intense".

Stars reflect the overall quality of reviews and our own independent assessment (5 stars=don't miss; 1 star=don't bother)

“Wuthering Heights” ★★★*Emerald Fennell’s lavish, much-anticipated adaptation of the gothic novel 2hrs 16mins (15)*

“You could never accuse Emerald Fennell’s ‘Wuthering Heights’ of being a faithful adaptation of Emily Brontë’s 1847 novel,” said Robbie Collin in *The Daily Telegraph* – “but then fidelity doesn’t appear to be remotely of interest to it. Resplendently lurid, oozy and wild, the new film from the director of *Salisbury* and *Promising Young Woman* is fixated on its central illicit affair, as conducted by Margot Robbie and Jacob Elordi, to the exclusion of almost all else. It’s an obsessive film about obsession, and hungrily embroils the viewer in its own mad compulsions.” I loved it.

*“Boy, do they have chemistry”*

We first meet Cathy as a child (Charlotte Mellington), running wild on a “super-stylised version of the Yorkshire Moors”, said Vicky Jessop in *The London Standard*. One day, her feckless father (an unrecognisable Martin Clunes) brings back from Liverpool a homeless child, Heathcliff (*Adolescence*’s Owen Cooper). Soon enough, the pair have become “implausibly gorgeous adults” (Robbie and Elordi) “who are clearly in love but separated through cruel circumstance (aka Heathcliff being poor, and Cathy being proud)”. The film is more “wholeheartedly romantic” than the novel. Heathcliff and Cathy have had their edges rubbed off, but “boy, do they have chemistry”; and their madly horny behaviour is “perfectly

matched by the costume and set design”. The result is a wildly fun, “ultra high-camp version of *Gone with the Wind*”.

Oh please, said Clarisse Loughrey in *The Independent*. Fennell has said she wanted to capture how she felt reading the book aged 14, but under “the guise of interpretation” (indicated by the inverted commas around the title) she has gutted one of the most impassioned novels ever written, then tossed “its flayed skin over whatever romance tropes seem most marketable”. Her film is “astonishingly hollow”, with zero narrative tension and a Heathcliff like a “Mills & Boon mirage”. He is “bizarrely uninteresting”, agreed Kevin Maher in *The Times*, and Cathy isn’t much better. Robbie

is old for the role, at 35. That might not have mattered in a better adaptation, but here it’s “mildly perplexing”: you wonder why she only started flirting with Heathcliff in her 30s. Both stars are marooned in a film full of “conspicuous longueurs and characterisations that barely reflect the complexity of an Instagram reel, let alone the greatest gothic novel in English literature”. “Less *Wuthering Heights*, more *Fifty Shades of Grimm*”, this handsome film has “lashings of kinky sex” but no soul, said Brian Viner in the *Daily Mail*. Ultimately, it’s an “empty exercise in style over substance”.

Send Help ★★★*Genre-busting comedy-horror-thriller starring Rachel McAdams Dir: Sam Raimi 1hr 53mins (15)*

Sam Raimi “is the furthest thing from a one-note director”, said Brian Viner in the *Daily Mail*: his “many credits” range from the Tobey Maguire *Spider-Man* trilogy to the *Evil Dead* franchise. *Send Help* is a further testament to his versatility, blending “comedy, social satire, survivalist-thriller and gross-out body-horror”, to often “compelling” effect. Rachel McAdams stars as Linda, a mousy office worker who is flying to a meeting in Thailand when the private jet she is in crashes into the ocean, and she becomes stranded on a desert island with her new boss – an “entitled, sexist, slimeball” (Dylan O’Brien) named Bradley. The narrative seems to be following a familiar trajectory, as Bradley learns to appreciate his underling’s survival skills (Linda is a dab hand



at building shelters). But then the story swerves into new territory – and for those with “a reasonably strong stomach”, what follows is good fun.

I’m afraid I wasn’t entertained by the plot twists, which seemed “derivative”, said Peter Bradshaw in *The Guardian*. And I found Raimi’s need “to juice everything up with spurious ‘horror’ flourishes” somewhat wearing. This “eat the rich” parable is undeniably gory, said Clarisse Loughrey in *The Independent*: its stars are variously drenched in vomit, “bug innards, fish innards, and, of course, several power showers’ worth of spattered blood”. But the story is told with real “wit and viscera”; and McAdams – who initially seems too “glamorous” for the role – acquits herself superbly.

My Father’s Shadow ★★★★*Touching and tender tale of two brothers in 1990s Nigeria Dir: Akinola Davies Jr 1hr 34mins (12A)*

A “coming-of-age film” with “inspired” casting, this Nigerian drama is set during that country’s turbulent 1993 presidential election, said Jonathan Romney in the *FT*. Mainly told over the course of one day, it opens with two boys aged eight and 11 (played by the brothers Godwin Egbo and Chibuike Marvelous Egbo) mucking around at home, when their father (Sopé Dirísù, known for TV’s *Slow Horses*), whom they barely know, turns up – and to their delight, takes them on a trip to Lagos. The film (in English, Yoruba and pidgin English) “is made in a mode that you might call Hallucinatory Realism: events and images flashing before the camera in the same rush that the boys experience them”. We get



a “panorama of 1993 Lagos, but also fleeting, arresting details (ants on a cracked wall, sand-speckled crabs on the beach)”. The overall effect is of a dream, and one “you want to experience again right away”. Director Akinola Davies Jr co-wrote the script with his own brother, Wale Davies, said Thomas Page on CNN. Their father died young, and so they were never able to spend the day scampering around after him in Lagos. The result is a “sad, serious and tender” film that also feels like a “devastating act of wish fulfilment”. Yet the father here is more than just a “ghostly ideal”, said Tim Robey in *The Daily Telegraph*. The way he interacts with his sons is just one of the highlights of a “magically nimble” film.

Exhibition of the week **Samurai**

British Museum, London WC1 (020-7323 8181, britishmuseum.org). Until 4 May

We think of samurai as fearsome warriors – and they were, said Neil Fisher in *The Sunday Times*. Yet if you visit Nomura Residence, an “elegant” house in the Japanese city of Kanazawa where generations of samurai lived, you’ll find it has delightful features, including an exquisite garden. Inside, you can see a fine piece of calligraphy – a letter written in 1566 to a samurai from his liege lord. “We appreciate that you worked so hard to kill one high-ranked soldier on the fourth of last month at the Yokokitaguchi Battle,” it says. “We are very happy that you brought us his head.” The story of the samurai is, you realise, a “bundle of contradictions” – “elegance and formality, banality and butchery” – and that is how it is presented in the British Museum’s “blockbuster” show. It explores the role of the samurai and their pop-cultural afterlife – and in so doing, it clears up a few misapprehensions. The biggest is that the samurai were a “military sect”, when for centuries they were more “a privileged tier of society” that helped ensure the smooth running of the state. During the Tokugawa shogunate (1603-1868), “about 10% of the population counted as samurai class”, half of whom were women.

The show takes you on a “scintillating journey” through “a world of gore, power and artistic beauty”, said Jonathan Jones in *The Guardian*. The samurai were not the first to believe that, in battle, the warrior is transformed into something other. The Vikings had their berserkers, for instance. “But no culture



Even empty, the suits here “pulse with menace”

has ever put quite as much creativity into blood-lust” as this one. When the samurai donned their armour – “so vital, so electric”, with their grimacing black masks – they would have seemed truly demonic. Even empty, the suits here “pulse with menace and mystery”. There are lots of weapons on show too, and images of samurai in bloody battle – but also a painting of a warrior stopping to smell the blossom he is riding past, and another of a samurai making love to a courtesan while two other women “caress the blade of his unsheathed sword”. That perhaps encapsulates the appeal of this exhibition: the samurai were lethal but sexy, their warfare violent yet theatrical.

For samurai, who “aspired to be sophisticated courtiers and held the arts in high regard, beauty and brutality were intertwined”, said Alastair Sooke in *The Daily Telegraph*. Some of their armour was positively dandyish; a 19th century quiver here glitters like a disco floor. The show is in three parts. The first covers the rise of the warriors as a fighting force in medieval times; the second – and most engrossing, in my view – is about the peaceful Tokugawa shogunate, when they morphed into bureaucrats; the third explores their impact on popular culture. The effect of this section, which includes comic books and an effigy of

Darth Vader, whose helmet was modelled on samurai armour, is bathetic, as if you’ve walked into a teenager’s bedroom. It’s a disappointing climax to an otherwise “riveting” exhibition.

Where to buy...

The Week reviews an exhibition in a private gallery

For John Constable

at Bernard Jacobson Gallery

Coinciding with Tate Britain’s landmark Constable/Turner face-off, this intriguing exhibition has a simple premise. It pairs an exquisite selection of Constable’s etchings with a treasure trove of 20th century works on paper that were inspired by his art. Thus we get a gorgeous Ivon Hitchens landscape, screen-printed in more shades of green than you ever knew were visible; an ingenious 1970s David Hockney etching depicting the catalogue from a Constable show, as well as various postcards the artist bought in the gift shop; a knowing William Tillyer abstract that nods to his precursor’s cloud studies; and a delicate bucolic scene by Duncan Grant. Unsurprisingly, however, it’s



Howard Hodgkin’s After Luke Howard (1976)

Constable himself who really thrills: his draughtsmanship transfers to plate like fish released back into water, the subtlety of tone between, say, storm cloud, rain shower and breaks of clear sky uncommonly fluent and never less than breathtaking. *For John Constable* is enthralling throughout. Prices range from £240.

8 Golden Square, London W1 (020-7734 3431). Until 27 February

Anish Kapoor’s space mission

For his next big project, Anish Kapoor plans to send a large sculpture into orbit, as a protest against the commercialisation of space. To ensure that it is visible from Earth, Kapoor says it will be about “the size of a house”, and might have mirrors to help it stand out. He did not reveal who is



sponsoring the project, which is likely to cost hundreds of millions, but confirmed that it wasn’t Elon Musk, whose attitude to space he “cannot stand”. The Mumbai-born British artist has made vast pieces before, including a shining steel structure in Chicago – inspired by liquid mercury – known as “the bean”, and the ArcelorMittal Orbit tower in London. The point of the new work will be that it is useless, he told *The Times*. “It is hard not to sound pompous, but what we are trying to do is bring back the early sense of adventure in space. It was a whole new frontier, but now there is a sense we are conquering it for other purposes – it is all about money.”

The week's guide to what's worth seeing

Showing now

The Europeans is an exhibition in Paris celebrating the reissue of Henri Cartier-Bresson's 1955 book of photographs of the same title, and consisting of his vivid images of a continent recovering from the ravages of the Second World War. Until 3 May, Fondation Henri Cartier-Bresson, Paris (henricartierbresson.org).

Hugh Bonneville has reprised his role as C.S. Lewis in this revival of the 2019 production of **Shadowlands**, about the writer's late-life romance with the American poet Joy Davidman (Maggie Siff). Until 9 May, Aldwych Theatre, London WC2 (shadowlandsplay.com).

See works by Elisabeth Frink, Barbara Hepworth, Bridget Riley and others at **People Watching**, an exhibition of British portraiture in modern times. Until 10 May, Dorset Museum and Art Gallery, Dorchester (dorsetmuseum.org).

Book now

At the age of 91, **Rose Wylie** is being given a solo show at the Royal Academy. Expect a joyous exhibition: her paintings of contemporary life are "exuberant, mischievous, infectious" and "versed in art history" (Daily Telegraph). 28 February-19 April, Royal Academy of Arts, London W1 (royalacademy.org.uk).

The regular quartet from Radio 4's topical satire *Dead Ringers* are taking part in the second leg of **Dead Ringers: The 25th Anniversary Tour** –



Cartier-Bresson's *Burgos, Espagne* (1953)

"pure joy" (Times). 1 March, New Theatre, Cardiff, then Glasgow, Basingstoke and on, until 29 March (fieryentertainment.com).

Sadie Sink (*Stranger Things*) and Noah Jupe (*Hamnet*) are the doomed lovers in Robert Icke's much anticipated production of **Romeo & Juliet**. 16 March-6 June, Harold Pinter Theatre, London SW1 (romeojulietplay.com).

Just out in paperback

Moral Ambition: Stop Wasting Your Talent and Start Making a Difference by Rutger Bregman (Bloomsbury £10.99). In this book, the Dutch historian who gave the 2025 Reith Lectures urges gifted individuals to use their skills to improve the world. "A bracingly hopeful perspective" (Guardian).

her own mind. In this, the second in the series, Madeline goes a step too far and we are introduced to Genevieve, the brave hound who saves her life.

My Dog, Hen by David Mackintosh, 2022 (available used). Written in the voice of a very direct child who dryly observes the antics of a tiny puppy, "He eats all his food. Then he eats the food bowl." The pictures are super stylish; the feelings soft and tender.

Caleb & Kate by William Steig, 1977 (available used). Reading anything by William Steig is a treat – the quirky language, the magic, the surprises and gentle humour are matched by the warmth and affection in the pictures. Kate's husband is turned into a dog by a witch, leaving Kate "dizzy with dread" about his disappearance. The dog is completely charming.

Best books...

Emma Chichester Clark

The author-illustrator picks her favourite children's books featuring animals. Her new book, The Good Deed Dogs, is published by Walker at £7.99; an exhibition of paintings, There's Always a Dog, is at the Aldeburgh Gallery, Suffolk, from 5-11 March



Aunt Amelia by Rebecca Cobb, 2013 (Macmillan £7.99). Aunt Amelia – a crocodile – is divine. She's in charge of two small bad-tempered children and we anticipate strict reform, at least. However, anarchy rules, and the parents' list of dos and don'ts is wildly misinterpreted. The colour, warmth and organised mayhem of the pictures are a complete joy.

The Boy Who Became a Parrot: A Foolish Biography of Edward Lear, Who Invented Nonsense by Wolverton Hill, illustrated by

Laura Carlin, 2025 (Enchanted Lion £16.99). The pairing of Laura Carlin with Edward Lear is genius. Her paintings, in subtle colour, create places where Lear would have lived and breathed, and her depictions of him and his family are intricate and tender. Lear's drawings join in as the story of his life and death is celebrated.

Madeline's Rescue by Ludwig Bemelmans, 1953 (available used). I love the work of Ludwig Bemelmans best of all and particularly his heroine, Madeline – a child who knows

Television

Programmes

Yellowjackets Mystery thriller set across two timelines. A high-school football team's plane crashes in the Canadian wilderness, with profound effects 25 years later. Sun 15 Feb, ITV1 22:15 & 23:20 (65mins and 60mins respectively).

The Tony Blair Story: Who Are You? Three-part series charting the story of Blair's meteoric rise and fall. Tue 17-Thu 19 Feb, C4 9pm (90mins, 90mins and 60mins).

Fukushima: Days That Shocked the World On 11 March 2011, Japan was rocked by the most powerful earthquake in the nation's history. This series talks to survivors and witnesses. Tue 17 & Wed 18 Feb, C4 22:00 and 22:30 (60mins).

Storyville: The Darkest Web Documentary following a network of specialist undercover police as they investigate online crime against children. Tue 17 Feb, BBC4 22:00 (90mins).

Films

Sleepless in Seattle (1993) Showing in time for Valentine's Day, Nora Ephron's unapologetically romantic classic starring Tom Hanks and Meg Ryan. Sat 14 Feb, Film4 21:00 (130mins).

M3GAN (2022) Entertaining yet chilling horror about a murderous cyborg doll, which was intended as a companion for an orphaned girl. Mon 16 Feb, Film4 21:00 (125mins).

Radical (2023) Based on true events, this is a charming tale of a failing school on the Mexican border that is turned around by an inspirational teacher. Tue 17 Feb, Film4 00:55 (160mins).

New to streaming TV

Under Salt Marsh Kelly Reilly and Rafe Spall star in this well-plotted series about the investigation into a young boy's death in a Welsh coastal town. On Sky Atlantic and Now.

Queen of Chess Gripping documentary about Hungarian child prodigy and chess grandmaster Judit Polgár. On Netflix.

Titles in print are available from The Week Bookshop on 020-3176 3835. For out-of-print books visit biblio.co.uk

Owing to changes at the BBC, we are unfortunately no longer able to publish a summary of *The Archers*

Romantic abodes



▲ **Wiltshire:** The Manor, Chitterne. This characterful Grade II Jacobean house with far-reaching views over Salisbury Plain is set in 9 acres of mature gardens and woodland. Period features include stone mullion windows, some with historic glass etchings. 6 beds, 3 baths, kitchen, 5 receps, garden, barn, paddocks, parking. £1.895m; Strutt & Parker (01722-328741).



▲ **Isle of Wight:** Cliff Dene, Bonchurch. Part of a charming Victorian villa (the ground floor and part of the first floor), the house is surrounded by mature gardens and enjoys an elevated position with panoramic sea views. 3 beds, 2 baths, kitchen, 3 receps, garden, parking. £650,000; Spence Willard (01983-200880).



◀ **Wiltshire:** Dial House, West Lavington. An elegant William & Mary Grade II* country house with lovely formal gardens. 6 beds, 3 baths, kitchen, 3 receps, swimming pool, tennis court, outbuildings, garden, parking. £1.85m; Savills (01722-426820).

► **Highland:** Tulach Ard, Loch Alsh. An 18th century farmhouse in a spectacular setting with approx. 5 acres of land. 6 beds, 4 baths, kitchen, recep, 1-bed annexe, sauna, garden, outbuildings, parking. OIEO £825,000; Inigo (020-3687 3071).





◀ **Norfolk:** Uphall, Hillington. A fine Grade II Georgian house close to the royal Sandringham Estate. The house is nestled within approx. 5 acres of gardens and woodland. 11 beds, 5 baths, 6 receps, kitchen/breakfast room, tennis court, swimming pond, coach house, outbuildings, garage. £2.25m; Sowerbys (01553-766741).

▼ **Dorset:** My Ladys Cottage, Fifehead Magdalen. Delightful Grade II thatched house which has been sympathetically extended. Includes a well-stocked mature garden and an ornamental pond. 4 beds, 3 baths, kitchen, 3 receps, garden, parking. £650,000; Hamptons (01722-563117).



◀ **West Sussex:** New Place Manor, Pullborough. An enchanting Grade II* manor house with a stone archway built for Queen Elizabeth I's visit in 1591. 7 beds, 5 baths, 5 receps, garden, 2-bed annexe, outbuildings, parking. £2.5m; Knight Frank (01428-770563).



▲ **Clackmannanshire:** Cowden House, Dollar. A handsome 1960s house, boasting a turreted folly, in a glorious rural setting on the former Cowden Castle estate. 5 beds, 3 baths, kitchen, 3 receps, garden, parking. OIEO £1.195m; Savills (0131-247 3797).

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Mambow 78 Lower Clapton Road, London E5 (mambow.co.uk)

"Let me tell you now, right from the outset", that the music at this restaurant is very loud, says Giles Coren in The Times. "Also, the place is quite dark." But if you can cope, you really should go, because the food is "absolutely knockout". Chef/proprietor Abby Lee is from a Chinese-Malaysian/Singaporean background – "the birth combo I revere above all others, food-wise" – and her cooking is "gloriously original, alive and confident". Tartare of wild seabass with green mango, green apple and red onion is "bound together in a sarawak laksa paste", resulting in "raw fish sorcery of the highest order". Grilled banana blossom, served in a salad, offers a "whole new mouthfeel": it's "spongy and bland", but also "strangely compelling"; grilled hogget is served "mamak-style", with strong curry aromatics. It's "just miraculous to experience such brilliantly controlled Malaysian cooking on an overwintered English sheep of this quality". Meanwhile, a hunk of beef short rib "the size of a guitar" is braised in coconut milk broth to perfection. Yes, Mambow may be a "bit noisy and the lighting isn't great" – but you'd be a fool to "give it a miss". *Three-course menu for £30, or about £70 a head.*

The Tin Roof Cafeteria & Bakery Bryants Lane, Maldon, Essex (01245-204666)

It isn't easy to get a table at this "all-day spot", next to the "vast Claremont Garden Centre", a few miles off the A12 in Essex, says Grace Dent in The Guardian. This



The Tin Roof: a "not-so-hidden gem"

place is "constant, scone-fuelled bedlam". Yet it feels, somehow, very 2026, because "eating early, soberly, with multi-generational tables – and, probably most importantly, while trying not to spend £100+ a head" – has become quite the aspiration. Come expecting nothing earnest or po-faced, just "down-to-earth dining, with fish finger baps, doorstep Burnham Banger sarnies and very good five-cheese toasties on sourdough". There are salads and burgers, pies and platters, as well as excellent "sweet stuff from the in-house bakery". And it really does feel as if all of life is here: "pensioner ladies who lunch, dating teenagers, couples with babies grabbing fresh air and the partners of green-fingered types bribed to carry top soil by a promise of eggs florentine and a round of berry financiers". At one point,

even a motorcycle gang arrives – though a "pleasant one", seemingly quite fond of bakewell tarts. The Tin Roof, in short, is a "not-so-hidden gem". *From about £15, plus drinks and service.*

Goat on the Roof 1 Bridge Street, Newbury, Berkshire (01635-580015)

This "local restaurant" in Newbury is the "kind of place that appeals to all", says Tom Parker Bowles in The Mail on Sunday. "Merry enough for a friends' night out", it is "quietly seductive too". Out of hours, it doubles as a wine shop, and bottles "line the wall, all well-priced and interesting". I suggest you ask the advice of the owner, Patrick Vaughan-Fowler, a man who "knows of what he speaks". As for the cooking, it is "never arch or pretentious", but rather "elegant, sensual and unashamedly voluptuous". Cheese and ham croquettes are "burnished globes of subtle beauty" – the shells "crisp and delicate", the centres a "molten morass of oozing delight". Pork belly comes with the fat expertly rendered, resulting in "curls of brittle crackling". A "brilliant" pheasant schnitzel, with a cider sauce, is "heavy on the butter and lardons". Sides are very good too. Whole carrots are slow-cooked in a tarragon sauce, which transforms the "everyday into the unforgettable". Roast potatoes sit in a "sharp tomato sauce, slathered with pungent aioli". I arrive meaning to ask why the place is called Goat on the Roof. "But the cooking's so good that it rather slips my mind." *About £40 per head.*

A chef's favourite recipe

This dish originates in the Loire, specifically the Touraine region where they make wonderful, gastronomic wines, says David Hart, chef-proprietor of Franc, a French restaurant and wine bar in Canterbury (franc-canterbury.com).

Tourangelle-style pork with prunes (*porc aux pruneaux de Tours*)

Vouvray is a village just east of Tours that produces every conceivable style of white wine – from dry and sparkling to dessert wines – using the chenin blanc grape. The best wine to use in this dish is "demi-sec", or off-dry, which together with prunes and cream creates the most magnificent sauce to go with pork.

Serves 4

½ bottle of demi-sec Vouvray wine

2 dozen pitted prunes

4 pork loin steaks around 2 cm thick and of fine provenance

a little sunflower oil

300ml double cream

a lemon

- At least a day before, pour the wine over the prunes and leave them to macerate. After about 24 hours the prunes will have plumped up nicely



and the wine will have taken on the flavour of the prunes.

- Take the pork loin steaks out of the fridge a good half an hour before cooking. Put a large heavy based frying pan on a medium to high heat and add a couple of tablespoons of oil.

- Season the steaks liberally with salt and brown them well for three minutes

on each side. Lower the heat, turn the pork over and cook for a further minute on each side. Remove the pork to a warm plate and pour over any pan juices. Loosely cover with foil while you make the sauce.

- Put the pan back on the heat and pour in the wine. Use a wooden spoon to dislodge all the caramelised brown spots on the bottom of the pan (these will dissolve into the sauce and add flavour).

- Boil down the wine until you have about 6 tablespoons of liquid, then add the cream. Once the sauce has come back to the boil, add the prunes along with any resting juices from the pork. Combine all and taste the sauce for seasoning. You may like to add a few drops of lemon juice to balance the sauce too.

- Serve the pork on hot plates with the sauce poured liberally over and around. Some spinach or mashed potatoes would work well alongside, as would, of course, a chilled bottle of Vouvray.

New cars: what the critics say



BMW iX3
from £58,755

Top Gear Magazine

The first in a line of a new generation of EVs – BMW is calling them the New Class, or *Neue Klasse* – the iX3 expunges “many or all of the annoyances of new-age EVs”. The car doesn’t feel “heavy or numb” to drive; it’s efficient; and charging times are “staggering” – you can pick up 200 miles of range in just ten minutes. It’s no exaggeration to say that the model marks a “revolution for BMW”.

What Car?

If you’re after a “big, comfortable”, premium electric SUV, this car ticks all the boxes. It strikes a “great balance between ride comfort and driving fun”; it disguises its heaviness remarkably well and it’s practical, with tons of room for passengers and a generous boot. There’s only one version available from next month, the “very quick” 50 xDrive, but cheaper models are on the way.

The Times

The cabin is particularly “hi-tech”, and features a digital strip that sits across the dashboard, to keep key information in the driver’s eyeline. There’s also an 17.9-inch infotainment touchscreen that features the usual controls for air con, radio and maps, but also supports apps such as Spotify and YouTube. You can even download Zoom – though you obviously won’t be able to take video calls while actually driving.

The best... “smart” eyewear



◀ **Lenovo Legion Glasses Gen 2** With two displays in the lenses and speakers in the frame, these 65g “aviator-style glasses” give a 126-inch virtual viewing experience – “ideal for watching videos or gaming”. Simply connect via USB cable running down the left arm. Prescription inserts are available, as is a light shield for “immersion” (£399; lenovo.com).

▼ **Nuance Audio** Nuance has discreetly incorporated a hearing aid into these “fairly standard-looking specs”, using speakers that send amplified sound into the ear canal. A full charge lasts 8-10 hours, so it’s best to turn them off when they’re not in use. Prescription lenses can be added (from £700; nuanceaudio.com).



▶ **Even Realities G2** These glasses don’t have speakers or a camera, but they provide an in-lens display that can show a range of text-based content, from stocks to news. The glasses can also be used as a teleprompter, a navigation aid, a real-time translation assistant and a fact checker. Prescriptions from -12 to +12 available (£599; evenrealities.com).



▲ **Oakley Meta Vanguard** An alternative to action cameras like the GoPro, these sunglasses have a 12-megapixel camera with a 122° wide-angle lens. They film in up to 3k resolution and have video stabilisation plus 32GB of storage, with headphones in the frames and a built-in mic for voice commands (£499; oakley.com).



▼ **Engo 2 Vive** Ideal for athletes who like to see their stats “in their field of vision at all times”, these glasses feature a projection system that “hugs around the bridge of the nose, and is small enough to get used to fairly quickly”. The data on show can include speed, elevation and heart rate; the glasses themselves weigh just 36g (£309; engoeyewear.com).



SOURCE: FINANCIAL TIMES

Tips of the week... busting common kitchen myths

- Most of the time there’s no need to wait for an oven to preheat before putting food in to cook. The only exception is baking, where precision can be important. Bear in mind that modern fan-assisted ovens generally heat up in just 8-9 minutes.
- You don’t need to use 70% chocolate for baking – 50% or 60% is fine. It’s often sweeter, so you can add a touch less sugar to whatever you’re baking, too. Save the expensive stuff for eating.
- Sausages no longer need pricking before cooking. This myth dates back to the First World War when “bangers” would burst open in the oven, owing to their higher water content.
- The idea that the hottest part of the chilli is the seeds is hogwash: it’s actually the white pith that holds the seeds in place.
- Root vegetables don’t need peeling. Unless the skin is gnarly like celeriac or thick like certain squash varieties, a good scrub should do the trick. Relish the extra fibre!

SOURCE: DAILY MAIL

And for those who have everything...



Spotted at Paris Fashion Week, these oversized Lego-brick Crocs are available from 16 February. The clogs also come with a Lego figurine that has four pairs of its own mini Lego-brick crocs.
£150; lego.com, crocs.co.uk

SOURCE: FINANCIAL TIMES

Where to find... the most scenic saunas in Britain

The first of its kind in Scotland, **HotBoat** is a wood-fired sauna that floats across Loch Tay. Plunge into the loch if you dare (2 hours for 6 people is £300; taysmouthmarina.com). Cradled at the foot of Lulworth Cove in Dorset, **Saltwater Sauna** has space for eight people; be sure to wade out into the cove’s still water afterwards (from £15 for 65 mins; thesaltwatersauna.com). **Aqua Sana** has a treetop sauna in the canopy overlooking **Sherwood Forest**. The fun continues in the forest below, with ice rubs, steam rooms and hot tubs (spa packages from £85; aquasana.co.uk). Set in 200 acres by the River Teifi in Wales, **Fforest Farm** has a cedar-barrel sauna, cold plunge and wood-fired hot tub (from £40 for 2 hours; coldatnight.co.uk/fforest-farm). **Rooftop Saunas** now has two sites in London – in **Hackney** and **Brixton** – both with spectacular views. There are private cabins, cold plunges and cool-down rooms (from £11 for 30 mins; rooftopsaunas.com).

SOURCE: THE DAILY TELEGRAPH

This week's dream: a thrilling foodie city in northern Japan

The capital of the wild northern island of Hokkaido, Sapporo feels like Japan's "last frontier", says Alex Halberstadt in *Condé Nast Traveller*, a place where "everyone is from somewhere else", and a newcomer can "cast off the shackles of their past and reinvent themselves". The city's fabric is overwhelmingly modern and "prosaic", and its people are chattier, more open and less bound by tradition than in, say, Osaka or Kyoto. Nowhere is this difference more evident than in its food scene, the "strangest and most fascinating" in the country. Hokkaido's "unspoiled" valleys and cold waters yield fabulously "flavourful" ingredients, and though Sapporo's restaurants can't reach the "culinary heights" of Kyoto's "hushed *kaiseki* pavilions", they are often "much more fun", making the city worth a visit for gastronomic thrills alone.

At Cucina Italiana Magari, for instance, the food did not strike me as very Italian, but it was "delectable" even so. I loved the creamy soup (like a New England clam chowder) "loaded" with



Sapporo: "hearty" street food and Japan's "most exciting wine scene"

region has Japan's "most exciting wine scene" – but the city is also famed for its ice cream. At Gyokusuien, it is plain and buttery, and served with green tea. At Tempura Masa, it has the dense, smooth texture of ripe mango. And at Nanakamado, you can get a two-foot-high sundae called a *shime* parfait, with 20 elements, from rhubarb sorbet to bamboo-charcoal-flavoured mascarpone.

mantis shrimp, milt (cod sperm sac) and *fugu* (the potentially lethal blowfish you need a licence to prepare). Also unmissable is Noa Hakobune (Noah's Ark), for its chargrilled seafood and its weird building (designed by the British architect Nigel Coates), decorated with biblical murals. Sapporo is also known for its "hearty" street food, including ramen, which is best sampled at Menya Saimi, a restaurant reminiscent of a "school canteen". Its noodle soup is "stunning".

It's worth visiting the hot springs at nearby Jozankei, where one secluded inn, Kasho Gyoen, offers in-room onsen baths and good Italian food (done straight). The Sapporo

Getting the flavour of...



Fossil hunting in the City of London

London sits in a "basin of clay", so the stones used to construct its buildings, paths and pavements were all imported from elsewhere. To hear some of their stories, take a neighbourhood walking tour with the urban geologist Dr Ruth Siddall, says Ben Lerwill in *The Guardian*. I chose her City of London one – a "mind-boggling" experience. We saw rocks from as far afield as Australia, China and Brazil, including some with fossils. There are 30cm-long orthocones (like "swimming carrots", said Siddall) in the steps of St Paul's Cathedral, and a vertebrate bone ("possibly a pterosaur") built into a nearby wine bar. My favourite rock, however, was the South African gneiss we saw in a co-working space in Houndsditch. It came from a two-billion-year-old meteorite impact crater, and has veins of black impact glass containing traces of extraterrestrial minerals. See londonpavementgeology.co.uk for more information, and book tickets at walks.com.

A living museum in Uzbekistan

The Silk Road city of Khiva is among the loveliest in Uzbekistan, but it receives far fewer visitors than Bukhara and Samarkand, says Joel Day in *The Daily Telegraph*. That's set to change with the launch later this year of a high-speed train service from the capital, Tashkent, which will cut journey times from 15 hours to seven. Go soon, then, to see its walled old town, the Itchan Kala, at its most peaceful. With its tiny lanes, "secret" stairways and grand squares lined with "palaces and mosques, madrasahs and mausoleums", it's an "open-air museum" that was well preserved during the decades of Soviet rule. Many of its buildings are tiled with glorious designs in turquoise and blue (pictured), but its most fascinating treasure is among its simplest – a 10th century mosque, the Juma Masjid, with 212 carved wooden columns and a well that was originally a Zoroastrian fire pit.

An arty stay in the heart of Sardinia

In the Costa Smeralda, Sardinia has one of the Med's most glamorous tourist destinations, but the island's interior is a world apart from its glitz, says Emma J. Page in *House & Garden* – "deeply agricultural" and steeped in tradition. Set next to the "rugged" Supramonte mountains, Su Gologone makes a great base. This family-run hotel has a huge collection of folk art, and offers a diverse range of art classes and outdoor activities. Ancient choral songs are sometimes performed during the communal feasts served in its terraced gardens, and there are wonderful artisans' studios to visit in nearby villages. Also unmissable are the street murals in Orgosolo. Dating back to the 1970s, they address social and political themes, and lend this former bandit town an "edgy air".

Hotel of the week



Giraffe Manor Nairobi, Kenya

This creeper-clad 1930s mansion on the outskirts of Nairobi is a place of "storybook wonder" thanks to the giraffes that "potter nonchalantly" around its grounds, sometimes poking their heads in at the windows, says Tatler. With its four-poster beds, it's "very *Out of Africa*". And though you'll feel as though you're staying in a private country house, it has the luxuries of a five-star hotel, including a gym and an "excellent" spa. Afternoon teas on the front lawn are a delight, with "fabulously chintzy" fine china, and there's an outdoor pool with "sweeping" forest views.

Doubles from about £1,050, full-board; thesafaricollection.com.

Entrepreneur behind Britain's first colour newspaper

Eddy Shah
1944-2025

Eddy Shah was a burly entrepreneur who, as the owner of a string of local newspapers, took on a powerful print union in the early 1980s, said *The Daily Telegraph*. The battle that followed was a test of Margaret Thatcher's new union-busting laws, and became so bitter that Shah's office was set on fire. But he fought on, broke the union's grip over the industry – and then launched his own national daily, *Today*, Britain's first full-colour newspaper.

Selim Shah was born in Cambridge in 1944. His father was an international lawyer – an Iranian, who'd moved to England to study at the University of Cambridge. His mother was English. A rebellious child, Eddy (as he became known later) was expelled from Gordonstoun and left home at 18. His first job was as a scene shifter in a theatre. In the 1970s, he worked as a floor manager at Granada TV, then got a job selling ad space for a freesheet in Manchester. This inspired him to start his own local paper – funded by selling his first home. By 1983, his Messenger Group owned six freesheets with a turnover of £5m. It was in that year that his battle with the mighty National Graphical Association (NGA) began.

He accepted, he said, that his workforce would be unionised, but refused to allow his new typesetting plant in Bury to be a closed shop (where all staff had to join the union). Warning its members that the new technology at the Bury plant would lead to large-scale job losses, the NGA began an escalating industrial action, in which non-union members were harassed and Shah received death



Shah: expelled from Gordonstoun

threats. At a time when his actress wife Jennifer (née White) was being treated for cancer, five coffins were sent to the home they shared with their three children; three were child-sized.

The NGA was heavily fined for secondary picketing (outlawed by the Employment Act 1980) but refused to pay, and arranged a mass picket of Messenger's Warrington plant – leading to violent scenes when thousands of police arrived to clear the pickets. The NGA finally conceded defeat in 1984. Two years later, Rupert Murdoch, who had watched all this keenly, would face down the print unions in a similar battle sparked by his decision to abandon “hot metal” typesetting at his papers, and have them printed instead at a new automated plant in Wapping, which he had had built in secret. Buoyed by his victory over the NGA, Shah then secured funding for *Today*, a middle-market tabloid. It was the first national to use computer photosetting; and its use of colour photos was a stunning departure from the “grainy” monochrome elsewhere, said *The Guardian*. But it was beset by technical difficulties, and his media rivals worked fast to keep its circulation down. He sold it in 1987 and it closed in 1995. In 1988, he tried again, with the Manchester-based *The Post*. It lasted five weeks.

After that, he sold Messenger for £40m, and turned to writing novels and investing in golf courses. His name had been largely forgotten when in 2012 he was charged with historic sex crimes – having sex with an underage girl in the 1990s. He admitted to having paid for sex, but denied being attracted to underage girls and was acquitted. Jennifer, who'd stood by him, died in 2023.

Much-loved actress who won an Emmy for *Schitt's Creek*

Catherine O'Hara
1954-2026

“Kevin!” With that one word, delivered to camera, Catherine O'Hara cemented her place in cinema history as one of the screen's most neglectful parents, said *The Guardian*. Her role in the 1990 box-office smash *Home Alone*, as the suburban mother who realises, mid-flight to Paris, that her youngest son (Macaulay Culkin) has been left behind, made her face familiar to millions. Many *Home Alone* fans, were not aware, however, that O'Hara had already developed a gift for quirky comic roles, which later made her a star of independent cinema. So there was some excitement during lockdown when they realised that Kevin's mother was now one of the stars of *Schitt's Creek*, the Netflix hit about a rich couple and their spoiled adult children who lose their fortune and move to a rural backwater.

As the self-centred but lovable ex-soap star Moira Rose, O'Hara wore a variety of outlandish wigs and had an affected accent that was “mystifyingly wayward”, said *The Guardian*. Her son David became “Dare-vid”, and “baby” was rendered “bare-bare”. The script, written by her friend Eugene Levy and his son Dan (who played her husband and son) also gave her some great one-liners. “What have I told you about putting your body on the internet?” Moira asks her daughter in one episode, before adding: “Never! Never without proper lighting!” For her sublime performance, she won both an Emmy and a Golden Globe.

Catherine O'Hara was born in Toronto into a Catholic family where, she said, “laughing and being funny” was encouraged.



O'Hara: “sublime” as Moira Rose

Via her brother's then-girlfriend, the actress Gilda Radner, she became involved in the Second City improv group, said *The New York Times*. There, she befriended Levy, among others, and when the troupe got its own TV sketch show, *Second City Television*, she became a star in Canada and won recognition in the US, too. Film roles followed, including in Martin Scorsese's *After Hours* and Mike Nichols's *Heartburn*. It was Tim Burton who elevated her to the A-list, said *The Times*, when he cast her in *Beetlejuice*. In one memorable scene, she had to dance like a deranged marionette to Harry Belafonte's *Day-O*. Burton also set her up with the film's production designer Bo Welch. She had taken a shine to Welch but had been too shy to ask him out. They married in 1992, and had two sons. She and Levy continued to work together in a series of Christopher Guest films beginning with *Waiting for Guffman* (1996), then in the mockumentaries *Best in Show* (2000) and *A Mighty Wind* (2003), and lastly in the comedy *For Your Consideration*, in 2006. By the time Levy co-created *Schitt's Creek*, he and O'Hara had known each other for about 50 years.

Schitt's Creek's success opened new doors. O'Hara had recently been nominated for a further Emmy for her role in the TV series *The Studio*, and in 2024 she was invited to the Oscars to hand out the award for hair and make-up. Paying tribute to its nominees, she noted that “the last thing we [actors] want is for anyone knowing what we really look like”. She had remained in touch with her on-screen son Culkin through the ups and downs of his adult life. She is survived by her husband and her actual sons.

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SCAN ME

Companies in the news ...and how they were assessed

Global Counsel: life after Mandelson?

This week, Palantir – the controversial US data analytics company – is to host “a lavish party” in Mayfair “to celebrate the next chapter in our partnership with the Ministry of Defence”. No prizes for guessing the elephant in the room on Wednesday, said Larisa Brown in *The Times*. Defence Secretary John Healey insists that the decision to award Palantir a £240m contract to “boost military AI and innovation” was his alone, but the Government is under pressure “to review the contract”, signed in December, thanks to Peter Mandelson’s link to the company. Palantir was a client of Global Counsel, the lobbying firm co-founded by the ex-minister in 2010. A year ago, as UK ambassador to Washington, he helped set up a meeting between Keir Starmer and the company’s top brass. That potential conflict of interest is one of many now under scrutiny as the political scandal surrounding the Epstein files threatens to engulf Global Counsel and its clients, said Ali Lyon in *City AM*. Co-founder and CEO Benjamin Wegg-Prosser, a former Labour spin doctor, resigned last week – and clients are defecting like rats. Barclays (whose CEO Jes Staley resigned over his Epstein links) has severed ties, “citing frustration over its efforts to divest Mandelson”, who until last week retained his 21% stake in the firm. GSK, the Premier League, Vodafone and the US buyout behemoth KKR have all followed. The new CEO, Rebecca Park, faces the mother of all battles to keep the consultancy alive.

NatWest/Evelyn Partners: pursuit of “mass affluence”

Bully for NatWest, said Lex in the *FT*. The bank, once known as RBS, has just announced “its most significant acquisition since the 2008 financial crisis”. It is thought to have outbid Barclays to secure wealth manager Evelyn Partners for £2.7bn, in a deal that will create one of Britain’s largest private banking and wealth management businesses (NatWest also owns Coutts). But it was sod’s law that the bank “picked a bad day” to do “a decent” deal. Shares fell 6% as worries about Keir Starmer’s future as PM rocked UK markets. “NatWest may have escaped UK government ownership, but it can’t wholly escape Downing Street’s influence.” In banking terms, the deal is highly “fashionable”, said Nils Pratley in *The Guardian*. All the big players are going after what they dub the “mass affluent” – a cohort that tends to mean those with at least £50,000 to invest, but in practice usually implies much more. And the timing is great as “the lucky Boomer and X generations” get older and seek to transfer wealth to their children. The stock market’s grumble is that “Evelyn is not cheap” and this deal is very much “one for the long term”. CEO Paul Thwaite is in for “a long chase, and NatWest is not the only runner”.

Kering: fashion rebound

Is Gucci back in fashion? Investors seem to think so, said Emily Hawkins on *This is Money*. Shares in the luxury fashion brand’s parent, Kering, soared by as much as 16% in Paris this week as they cheered signs of recovery under new CEO Luca de Meo, who ran carmaker Renault before joining the group last September. True to his background, de Meo has promised to build “a leaner, faster Kering”. Now he claims that the group, which also owns Bottega Veneta and Balenciaga, is “rebounding from its lowest point”. That’s one way of putting it. Gucci sales actually dropped 10% in the last quarter, though that was better than the 12% fall forecast.

Seven days in the Square Mile

The Bank of England kept **interest rates** on hold at 3.75% as expected, but a knife-edge vote raised expectations of a rate cut at its next two meetings. The Bank lowered its outlook for **UK growth** in 2026 to 0.9%, from the 1.2% forecast in November, and predicted that **unemployment** would tick higher this year, to 5.3%. But it published a much more reassuring inflation forecast. Governor Andrew Bailey said that CPI inflation could drop to the Bank’s target of 2% at “some point in the spring”.

New analysis showed that Rachel Reeves’s last **Budget** was accessed nearly 25,000 times before its formal release, raising further questions over the OBR’s data handling.

US markets bounced back strongly from last week’s tech rout, before another AI-related selloff hit. Shares in some of the UK and US’s largest wealth managers tumbled after the US platform Altruist launched a tool that helps financial advisers personalise clients’ investment strategies. **St. James’s Place** fell by 13% on Wednesday. **Quilter**, **Aberdeen** and **AJ Bell** also took hits.

Mining giant **Rio Tinto** dropped its takeover bid for **Glencore**, which would have created a \$200bn FTSE-based company. A federal jury in Arizona found **Uber** liable in the rape of a passenger by one of its drivers and awarded the victim \$8.5m. **Tesco** is to open 70 new Express stores – including five on former **Amazon Fresh** sites in London.

Stellantis: an electric shock in Milan

General Motors and Ford have already taken sizeable write-downs on their electric vehicle businesses. But when Stellantis followed suit with a roughly \$26bn (€22bn) charge last week, the sense of shock was palpable, said *The Wall Street Journal*. Shares in Europe’s second-largest motor manufacturing group – formed by the merger of Fiat Chrysler Automobiles and Peugeot-Citroën owner PSA in 2021 – suffered a “record one-day drop”, plunging by 25% during chaotic trading in Milan. And with new CEO Antonio Filosa admitting to losing touch with the “real-world” needs (and wallets) of drivers, Stellantis’s US-listed stock fell by a like amount.



A Stellantis concept EV: “purged”?

Filosa’s decision to scale back Stellantis’s electric ambitions – and sell its stake in a Canadian battery joint venture – marks “the dismantling of one of the industry’s most gung-ho EV strategies”, said the *FT*. Carlos Tavares, his predecessor, had pledged that EVs

would “account for all of its European passenger vehicle sales” by 2030, “and 50% of its US ones”. But the group has been among the hardest hit by the slower than expected move away from petrol. “Stellantis bulls will say this is a ‘kitchen sink’ moment,” noted Tom Narayan of RBC Capital Markets. But a further “purge” of the group’s “huge collection of often overlapping brands”, ranging from Jeep to Alfa Romeo, is now felt to be “mandatory”, said Neil Winton in *Forbes*.

Stellantis and other Western groups face “a long, hard, expensive road” back to recovery, said Matthew Lynn in *The Sunday Telegraph*. Their botched gamble on EVs, exacerbated by unmeetable deadlines set by “fanatical” politicians, has cost tens of billions in capital and opened the door to Chinese brands like BYD, which will now be very hard to displace. The EV debacle will go down as “one of the worst self-inflicted calamities of recent industrial history”.

Issue of the week: the tech reset

Tech workers have worried for years about the AI tidal wave coming for their jobs. Has it finally arrived?

Would you back Google in a hundred years' time? Now's your chance to gamble, said James Titcomb in The Daily Telegraph. Google's parent company, Alphabet, plans to issue a rare 100-year-bond in sterling, as part of its wider plan to fund a \$185bn spending blitz on AI infrastructure. Other US firms – Disney, Coca-Cola, IBM among them – issued similar US bonds in the 1990s, but only three entities – the University of Oxford, the Wellcome Trust and French-backed energy giant EDF have previously issued sterling-based “century bonds”. The willingness of investors to lock in long-term capital reflects a big perception shift, said TradingView. “Once seen as cyclical and vulnerable to disruption, hyperscale tech firms are increasingly viewed as critical infrastructure providers.” But Google's move has also “added a new dimension to the debate over how far tech giants are willing to go to finance the AI boom” at a precarious time in the market. Last week, For More Magazines Check Soft.ac more than \$1trn was knocked off the value of some of the largest tech companies – building on a rout gaining steam through January.

“The market's concern is two-fold,” said Tom Howard in The Times. While the likes of Amazon and Meta have been assailed again by doubts over whether they can recoup their massive AI investments, a new front has opened up – with data and software



Google: planning a \$185bn spending blitz on AI

The worries look overdone, said The Economist. True, AI tools might make it much easier for client companies to write their own code. But “building software is a distraction from their core business” that most would rather avoid. Indeed, SaaS companies are probably the best placed to layer AI tools on top of their existing propositions. Nonetheless, the fear that won't go away is that AI “simply works too well” in some of these functions, said Katie Martin in the FT. One has to conclude that the market has shifted from the “every tech stock is a winner” mindset to “something far more brutal” – a true “winners and losers landscape”, said Deutsche Bank analyst Jim Reid. It looks rather as if tech is “eating itself”.

Red-hot Asia: what the experts think

● “Takaichi trade”

Japanese stocks jumped to record levels after a landslide election win which handed PM Sanae Takaichi the biggest government majority in decades. In the resurgent “Takaichi trade”, the Nikkei 225 benchmark gained nearly 6%, said the FT, breaking through the 57,000 level for the first time as investors bet on her vision of a “strong, prosperous” nation. Takaichi pushed through a stimulus package in November (worth about \$120bn today) that will enable her “to drive corporate investment in key tech sectors” more easily now, and unleash consumer spending. Japan's borrowing costs climbed, the yield on ten-year bonds hitting 2.29%, “heading back to January's peak – the highest since 1999”. For now, “long-term investors are still in wait-and-see mode”, said Nomura's Tomochika Kitaoka: bond vigilantes are giving Takaichi the benefit of the doubt.

● The Japanese “normal”

Nobel Prize-winning economist Simon Kuznets used to joke there are four types of economy: developed economies, developing ones, Argentina and Japan. “There still are,” said Merryn Somerset Webb on Bloomberg. Japan remains “the



Takaichi: a vision worth betting on?

world's least normal economy”. Few nations have undergone the type of “bubble and bust” it experienced in 1989, and “no other modern economy has seen deflation over such a lengthy period” or such continuous population collapse. “Depopulation and high levels of debt are supposed to destroy

economies.” Yet both CEOs and young workers remain solidly optimistic. Japan isn't as cheap as it was, but it is “investable” and “most international investors are still a little underweight”.

● Regional strength

Japan will also benefit from the “bull run” across Asia's emerging economies, said The Economist. Yes, this has been boosted by the “sell America” trade, but even your “ardent America First investor” might ponder the cheapness of many Asian stocks and their “potential to benefit from global growth”. Thanks to governance reforms, investing in EMs is far less risky than it used to be. US tech giants may mint extraordinary profits from AI, but so too will firms in China, South Korea and Taiwan. “Investors buying a broad basket of EM stocks can bet on the same trend for a far lower price – and with more diversification in case AI disappoints.”

First-time buyer deals

Painful milestone Average house prices have topped £300,000 for the first time, according to Halifax – a “milestone” that will please existing owners, but push many more first-time buyers into “stamp duty territory”, said Joe Wright in The Daily Telegraph. Any purchase above £300,000 triggers the 5% land tax for new buyers which, as Karen Noye of Quilter observed, is “yet another nail in the coffin” for those “already battling stretched affordability”.

Slashed deposits Surveys suggest that raising a deposit is the biggest barrier to buying a home, said James Pickford in FT Money, and lenders are responding. Santander's new mortgage allows first-timers to borrow up to 98% of a house's value with just £10,000 – a move likely to spur rivals into “improved deals”. Some already offer 100% Loan to Value (LTV) mortgages. But there are catches. Melton Building Society's five-year fix at 5.99% is only available to buyers in the East Midlands; Skipton's deal hinges on the borrower's record of rental payments.

Trade-offs The penalty on such deals for the higher risk of default is higher interest rates, said Ian Cowie in The Sunday Times. Santander's deal comes at a “fairly demanding” 5.19% fixed rate over five years, compared with 3.73% charged by NatWest for those with a 40% deposit. If only this market “had the equivalent of Ryanair” to gee it up.

Bond markets in a jitter over Labour

Jack Barnett

The Times

The expression “moron risk premium” was coined nearly four years ago, by economist Dario Perkins of TS Lombard, to describe the market’s response to the economic mismanagement of the short-lived Liz Truss government. However you view Rachel Reeves’s record, the current Chancellor has at least reduced that premium, says Jack Barnett. She’s broadly trusted by bondholders for understanding the UK’s fiscal constraints and the importance of sticking to the rules. Indeed, under her budget plans, Britain is poised to embark “on the largest deficit reduction in the G7”. But the latest bout of turmoil in the Labour Party has revived fears of a reversal. Economists reckon that “a more left-leaning duo at the top” could send UK gilt yields higher by as much as 0.6%. Some on the Left deride politicians for being “in hock” to bond markets. Yet a financial crisis would constrain any future, more left-inclined government even more than this one. As the general election draws nearer, the market will pay close attention to Labour’s poll ratings. If support does not improve, expect attention to switch to “the economic ramifications of a Farage premiership”.

Reform UK vs. the Bank of England

Editorial

The Economist

Nigel Farage’s proposal to stop paying banks interest on their reserves held at the Bank of England – he claimed in 2024 it could save the government £35bn (or about 1% of GDP) a year – has found “rare common cause” with left-wing Greens and assorted financial technocrats, says *The Economist*. They should beware the lure of “fiscal fool’s gold”. The policy may sound “less reckless” than “permanently enforcing net-zero immigration” and other Reform UK proposals, but it would inflict real damage on central-bank independence. Plus, it’s questionable how much cash would actually be raised: in 2024, QE-related reserves held at the Bank exceeded £750bn and rates were above 5%. Both figures have already fallen; by 2030, the policy would probably raise no more than £10bn annually. The greater danger is what “unremunerated reserves” (i.e. interest-free debt) would mean for the economy. For any government short of cash, they’d be “fiscal catnip” – tempting politicians to lean heavily on the BoE to run large future QE programmes that replace gilts, on which interest must be paid. There are easier – and safer – ways to raise taxes on bank profits.

Bitcoin still defies gravity, but it can’t last

Jemima Kelly

Financial Times

In the brilliant 1995 French film *La Haine* (released in the US as *Hate*), there is the story of a man falling from a skyscraper who comforts himself by repeating: “*jusqu’ici tout va bien*” (so far, so good), says Jemima Kelly. “And *jusqu’ici*, the shills and shamans of bitcoinland have been getting away with it too.” Yes, there have been crashes, but every time bitcoin falls, it’s bounced back – buoyed by the “excessive confidence” of bitcoiners – when it has long been clear that the scheme would end up “splattered on the ground”. That moment is growing closer. Bitcoin has seen its worst crash since 2022, having more than halved in price since October’s \$127,000 record high and erased all the gains made since Donald Trump’s re-election. America currently has a “bitcoin president”, with vested family crypto interests. If bitcoin cannot thrive in this environment, when can it? We might not have reached the final death spiral, but the supply of “greater fools” on which it depends is drying up. The painful lesson learnt is that “there is no floor in the value of something based on nothing more than thin air”.

MrBeast has made a fintech revolution

Christer Holloman

Forbes

America’s top YouTube star, Jimmy Donaldson – aka MrBeast – is trading his trademark “viral stunts” for a new career as a banker, says Christer Holloman. His company Beast Industries has just acquired the teen-focused banking app Step, for an undisclosed sum (it was last valued at \$1bn in 2021). This isn’t just a novelty “influencer buys a bank story”, it’s far more punchy – a “vertical integration that solves the most expensive problem in fintech: customer acquisition”. Fintech companies typically spend millions on digital ads to lure users; MrBeast, with 467 million subscribers on YouTube alone, can achieve the same result with a 15-minute video. He is “positioning himself as the primary financial gateway for Gen Z and the generations to follow”. Thanks to Step’s “robust infrastructure”, “MrBeast Financial” now has “a turnkey engine” to power credit cards, student loans, insurance products et al to young punters inspired by his “financial literacy” content. Donaldson is proving that, for the next generation of billionaires, “attention isn’t just a metric, it is the ultimate capital”.

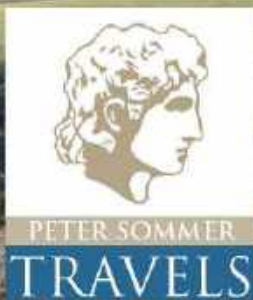
City profile

Will Lewis

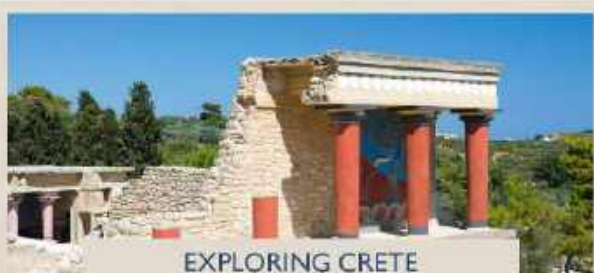
The day after axing a third of The Washington Post’s newsroom, the newspaper’s British publisher and CEO, Will Lewis, was spotted on the red carpet at a pre-Super Bowl party in San Francisco. Juxtaposition of this image with the abrupt shuttering of the Post’s sports department “drew widespread outcry”, said The New York Times. And for owner Jeff Bezos it was the last straw. By Saturday, Lewis, 56, was also out – marking the end of a tumultuous two-year turnaround effort that failed to stem losses and sparked an internal civil war that had journalists attempting to investigate Lewis’s own “journalistic ethics” following the UK phone-hacking scandal. Lewis hadn’t addressed the newsroom in person since 2024, and was absent during the critical Zoom call announcing the layoffs.



Lewis grew up in Hampstead Garden Suburb and, after Bristol University, started as a business reporter on The Mail on Sunday and the FT. His ascent was rapid. At 37, he became The Daily Telegraph’s youngest-ever editor in 2006 – scoring a coup when the newspaper broke the story of the MPs’ expenses scandal, before jumping ship to Rupert Murdoch’s News Corp. In 2023, he was knighted in Boris Johnson’s resignation honours list. Lewis “had won admirers” during his stint on Fleet Street and hopes were initially high when he joined the Post, said the FT. By the end, he stood accused of the “attempted destruction of a great American journalism institution” by a Post union rep. He is now, like more than 300 other journalists, looking for a new job.



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Who's tipping what

The week's best shares

Filtronic*The Motley Fool*

Filtronic designs and makes mission-critical communication networks. Not cheap and revenues can be lumpy, but the balance sheet is strong and it is winning major contracts in two big growth markets: space and defence. Buy. 184p.

GSK*Investors' Chronicle*

Operational improvement has boosted the drug giant after a long restructuring period, and higher-margin medicines are delivering profit growth. A "productive" dev pipeline, helped by its AI platform, bodes well. Buy. £20.13.

Lloyds Banking Group*The Times*

Britain's biggest mortgage lender's stock has surged 120% in two years, thanks to continued diversification and digitisation. Shares are down on rate-cut worries, but there's further growth to come. Buy. 105.8p.

Next 15 Group*Citywire*

This "crisis-hit" comms and marketing group is "undervalued", given new management's clear growth targets. Despite cutting the target price from 580p to 510p, Berenberg sees re-rating potential. Buy. 291p.

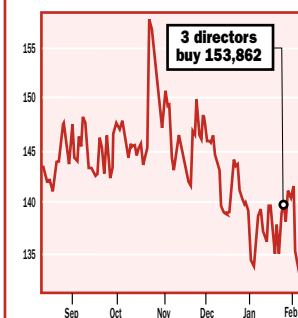
Venture Life Group*Investors' Chronicle*

The self-care and healthy-living products specialist has bolstered its management team and marketing investment to boost hormonal health and core "power brands", including H&H, Lift and Earol. Revenues are rising. Buy. 67.5p.

YouGov*Citywire*

The polling and analytics group is investing in product development and AI. Trading down – but "on the cusp of launching new tools that could drive growth", says Peel Hunt, giving a 535p target. Buy. 208p.

Directors' dealings

NCC Group

The IT security services firm has confirmed the \$369.4m sale of its Escode software business and launched a £70m buyback. A trio of directors, including chair Chris Stone, demonstrated faith in NCC's new pure-play status – buying shares worth £214,571.

SOURCE: INVESTORS' CHRONICLE

...and some to hold, avoid or sell

Fresnillo*Citywire*

After a "simply stellar run" driven by improved ops and the soaring silver price, Berenberg has downgraded the world's largest primary silver miner from "buy" to "hold", but increased the target to £38. Fairly valued. Hold. £36.32.

Inspiration Healthcare*Investors' Chronicle*

The neonatal intensive care medical devices specialist has entered a purchasing agreement with a large US healthcare provider. Debt is forecast to fall as profits rise. Could attract predatory interest. Hold. 15.5p.

SIG*Citywire*

Deutsche Bank has downgraded the insulation group, which has lost 69% of its value in five years, predicting SIG will remain loss-making and free cashflow negative. Target slashed from 13p to 5p. Sell. 9p.

Greggs*Sharecast*

Management has referenced softer consumer spending and unfavourable weather, but Jefferies blames weakening sales on weight-loss drugs. Still, Greggs is a "quality operator" with a strong brand and robust cash generation. Hold. £15.98.

Oxford Instruments*The Times*

The hi-tech products and services provider is responding to tariff uncertainty by renegotiating deals and shifting manufacturing sites. Augmented reality and Big Data applications are driving growth. Hold. £24.70.

WH Smith*The Times*

Profits have crashed amid a US accounting scandal and FCA probe. Still, the UK business is "strong" – driven by food-to-go, health and beauty, and one-stop airport and hospital shops. The new CEO has an impressive record. Hold. 691p.

Form guide

Shares tipped 12 weeks ago

Best tip
Morgan Advanced Materials
Sharecast
up 16.43% to 241p

Worst tip
Relx
The Times
down 37.76% to £21.46

Market view

"The pace of AI innovation is so fast that basically every week there's a new tool being launched – the market is looking for the next AI loser."

Emmanuel Cau of Barclays.
Quoted in the FT

Market summary

Key numbers for investors

	10 Feb 2026	Week before	Change (%)
FTSE 100	10353.84	10314.59	0.38%
FTSE All-share UK	5579.84	5555.63	0.44%
Dow Jones	50359.69	49019.45	2.73%
NASDAQ	23225.11	23211.24	0.06%
Nikkei 225	57650.54	54720.66	5.35%
Hang Seng	27183.15	26834.77	1.30%
Gold	5024.43	4949.17	1.52%
Brent Crude Oil	68.73	67.47	1.87%
DIVIDEND YIELD (FTSE 100)	2.87%	2.87%	
UK 10-year gilts yield	4.51	4.62	
US 10-year Treasuries	3.26	4.29	
UK ECONOMIC DATA			
Latest CPI (yoy)	3.4% (Dec)	3.2% (Nov)	
Latest RPI (yoy)	4.2% (Dec)	3.8% (Nov)	
Halifax house price (yoy)	1.0% (Jan)	0.3% (Dec)	
£1 STERLING:	\$1.367 €1.147 ¥209.481		Bitcoin \$69,494.00

Best and worst performing shares

WEEK'S CHANGE, FTSE 100 STOCKS		
RISES	Price	% change
Croda International	3201.00	+17.99
Burberry Group	1215.00	+13.28
GSK	2168.00	+11.44
Coca-Cola HBC AG	4478.00	+10.08
Mondi	936.00	+9.24
FALLS		
Metlen Energy & Metals	€31.28	-18.28
Natwest Group	605.00	-12.85
Lloyds Banking Group	103.00	-8.70
Babcock International	1364.00	-7.08
St James's Place	1449.00	-6.70
FTSE 250 RISER & FALLER		
Playtech	352.00	+25.76
Softcat	1146.00	-16.59

Source: FT (not adjusted for dividends). Prices on 10 Feb (pm)

Following the Footsie



6-month movement in the FTSE 100 index

Welcome to Slab City: California's town with no laws

A former military base in the desert has been turned into a makeshift city, attracting thousands of people who want to live outside normal society. It is often described as “the last free place in America” – but what is life really like there? Jack Burke reports

“Everyone here is insane,” says a man who introduces himself as Wizard. He is holding a staff, and uses it to gesture to the desert around us. A long white beard trickles over the slogan on his T-shirt: “I support sex workers”. Wizard, in his late 70s, has lived in Slab City for close to 30 years. He describes himself as an amateur sociologist, which is a polite way of saying he has spent decades watching broken people arrive, then try (and normally fail) to knit themselves back together.

Slab City is often described as “the last free place in America”. In reality, it’s a collection of semi-permanent camps squatting on roughly 640 acres of federal land in southern California. There is no running water, electricity, taxes, or government

infrastructure of any meaningful kind. Instead, motorhomes (RVs) sit alongside homes hammered together from reclaimed wood and corrugated metal. On the outskirts, tents sag and tear in the desert wind. Everything is the colour of old blood and oxidised tin, shimmering in desert heat that can soar beyond 50°C.

Slab City is a mythic place, the subject of endless breathless documentaries and photo essays. It is usually framed as an anarchic utopia, full of Americans opting out, artists rejecting capitalism, veterans finding peace off-grid. But what is it like in reality? Today, depending on the season, anywhere from a few hundred to a few thousand people live there, and few would describe it as a utopia. Drugs are everywhere. The heat is punishing and the living conditions brutal. People who have slipped through the cracks of American life arrive carrying trauma, addiction and paranoia, and the desert has a way of amplifying it all. If Slab City really is the last free place in America, what does that say about the rest of the country?

If anyone’s to blame for Slab City, it’s the US military. During the Second World War, American strategists believed this stretch of desert, 50 miles north of the Mexican border, would be the perfect place to prepare troops for a potential North African campaign. Hot, arid and brutal, it was a convincing simulation of the Libyan or Tunisian desert. By 1942, Camp Robert H. Dunlap, as it was called, contained dozens of buildings, many with concrete foundations. When the camp was eventually decommissioned in 1959, wooden structures were demolished and equipment was hauled away, but the concrete “slabs” were left behind, along with a few miles of unexploded ordnance, and were subsequently reused as foundations for the new makeshift homes.



The city is often framed as an anarchic utopia for artists, hippies and veterans

The first settlers were veterans and workers connected to the nearby military installations. Later came drifters, then RV owners looking for a free place to park for the winter. Slab City remained marginal until the late 1970s, when an article in an RV magazine reframed the slabs as an opportunity: come to Slab for free land, balmy winters, and like-minded people. By the 1980s, Slab City had become a seasonal migration point, with a few hundred people settling in for the winter months and thousands more passing through each year. They gave themselves a name: Slabbies. Everyone else: Normies. Today, that pattern remains pretty much unchanged. There are a few hundred year-round residents, and then there are “the snowbirds”, the migratory population who arrive in October, swell the numbers tenfold and leave again in spring.

October, swell the numbers tenfold

To drive to Slab City from Los Angeles, you leave the manicured desert oasis of Palm Springs and head into Imperial County. This is farmland California, hardscrabbled and poor. After about three hours, the town of Niland appears, which is the last outpost before you start spotting the slabs. On the outskirts of Slab City, the first thing you stumble across is Salvation Mountain, a huge, artificial technicolour hill, emblazoned with evangelical all-caps

messages: GOD IS LOVE etc. It is the work of Leonard Knight, an evangelical drifter and original Slabbe who spent decades building the monument and sleeping in a truck at its base, refusing money and help.

Old footage on YouTube shows a man with cracked leathery skin and a gentle voice. He died in 2014. Today, the mound is besieged by day-visitors. “Most people turn around here,” a volunteer tells me. “They tick Slab City off without ever seeing it.”

Carry on beyond Salvation Mountain and dwellings come into view. Signs line the dirt track: “No entry”; “F**k off normies”. Ironically, the anarchic utopia of Slab City is navigable on Google Maps. There are notional street names, arranged in the Americanised grid. Despite the handful of people who moved here “to escape 5G”, there’s 5G signal here too. Even Amazon delivers. It is the most on-grid off-grid place in America. On the edge of the camp, Dot’s home rises out of the sand like a child’s imagination left unattended for 20 years. Sculptures sprout from the desert floor, lashed together from whatever people have abandoned or dragged here. A 50-year-old Greyhound bus, silver skin dulled to the colour of old cutlery, leans at an angle, stuffed full of clothes, costumes and fabrics. At the entrance is a donation

“Slab City is navigable on Google Maps, there’s a 5G signal, and even Amazon delivers. It may be the most on-grid off-grid place in America”

box: “Suggested: \$5”. Dot, a spry woman in her early 50s with cropped blonde hair, is halfway through a tour. Two Midwesterners in jorts follow her round, gawping and pointing. When they leave, the performance begins afresh for me. “I didn’t come here to be free,” she explains. “I came here because it was the only place that didn’t ask me to be anything.”

Dot moved to Slab City five years ago after a spell living on the road, selling art out of an RV and finding the freedom more stressful than liberating. Here, she says, the audience is captive and the work gets seen. Her home doubles as one of the settlement’s informal attractions, advertised as “House of Dots”. She describes the two kinds of people who live here. There are the older residents, who see themselves as stewards rather than squatters. They organise clean-ups and mediate disputes; they believe, genuinely, in Slab City as a place with values. Then there are the “wreckheads”, who see Slab City as a place to party. “You’re not here on a Monday – that’s when the kids go wild.” In the late afternoon, Dot explains, dreadlocked twentysomethings descend on Slab’s decades-old skate park, speakers blasting, dogs barking, fires burning in oil drums. Meth pipes pass from hand to hand. Fortunately, it’s Saturday when I visit, which, Dot tells me, means the weekly open-mic night at The Range.

The desert is pitch black by the time I reach The Range, right in the centre of Slab City. A stage cobbled together from pallets and scrap metal glows under strings of coloured bulbs. Around 40 people look on. Our MC tonight, as every Saturday, is Builder Bill – a 77-year-old desert Father Christmas with a bushy beard, big belly and braces. He introduces one act after another, taking nips from a hip flask between announcements. Just as Dot promised, there’s a definite split: an older, hippyish crowd to one side, relishing their one social function of the week, and opposite a constellation of methheads and a group in their 20s. “I don’t abuse drugs,” one gloats. “I treat them well.”

For the older contingent there’s a burger stand, and standing in line I meet Steve, a man in his mid-50s double-fisting cans of Budweiser. “South Dakota,” he says, lifting one can in half-salute. “Been coming here ten years.” I ask how he finds it. “If you’re steady, you’re fine,” he replies. “If you ain’t, this place’ll find that out real quick. Drugs are a problem, and it tends to attract a... certain kind of person.” Steve laughs when I ask what happens to those people. “Cops are out here most days now,” he says. “People think it’s the Wild West. It’s more like a neglected neighbourhood where the police only show up if something’s on fire or someone’s been killed.” And what of disputes between residents? “Oh, it’s self-policing,” Steve replies. “Always has been... We got an unofficial sheriff. We call it ‘slab justice’.” If someone behaves badly, he explains, first they get the soft touch. They’re told to leave, driven to Niland, and dumped at the crossroads. If they don’t go, their camp goes up in flames. Later, I’m told this happens at least once a month. When I ask Steve what kind of behaviour earns a burnout, he doesn’t hesitate. “Paedophiles,” he says. “They get out or they die.”

The Oasis, just off the main drag, is the closest thing in Slab City to a community centre. It opens early, and when I arrive at 8am the next morning, the mercury is already nudging 30°C (86°F). A woman pours coffee into mismatched mugs. She introduces herself as Beryl, from Chicago, and offers me a cup. Builder Bill, last night’s MC, arrives, and starts describing his journey from San Diego in 1998. He was homeless, needed a place to live,



Residents have dubbed themselves “Slabbies”

and stumbled across Slab City. “I could’ve ended up in prison,” he says. “But I ran away out here.”

He believes every society should have a Slab City: “It’s like a pressure release valve. Where would these people go otherwise?” Bill describes the Flamingo Camp – a cluster of tents on the outer limit of Slab City. It’s a village for queer and transgender people who fell out of their hometowns and ended up here. “They accept you,” he says. “Doesn’t matter if you haven’t got money. They won’t judge you.” What about the Monday “wreckheads”? He grunts.

“Dreadlocked children,” he mutters. “Their only reference point for freedom is their mum not telling them what to do. They normally leave with the snowbirds.”

Before they leave, the snowbirds usually stop by Slab City’s “gift shop”, slightly outside the main grid. For sale are Slab City T-shirts, trinkets, stickers, all made by local artists. \$10 will get you a hand-stamped Slab City dog tag. The shop’s owner is Jimi Austin James, a former travelling musician who has lived in Slab City for 18 years. “It’s pure hell in the summer,” he says immediately, as if to correct any lingering romance. “And I’m here year-round.” Jimi and I go for a drive, which reveals that just as there are two types of people in Slab City, there are also two types of dwelling. The “nice camps” have solar panels and small gardens, and look like off-grid Pinterest boards. Further east, there is the other Slab, where ordered dysfunction is replaced by a cluster of tents. Burned-out sites leave black scars in the sand.

People of indeterminable sex and age lie passed out on the ground in the heat, bodies flattened by sun and drugs.

“People stay up for days out here,” Jimi says, shaking his

head. “Three days, sometimes more, no sleep, just meth and gear and whatever someone’s handed them that week. And after a while they don’t know what’s real any more. They think someone’s stolen from them, money or dope or something they can’t even remember having, and half the time it’s just been moved or lost, but by then it doesn’t matter because they’re already convinced.” From there, the escalation is almost procedural. “One camp goes up,” he continues, “and then the other person figures they’ve got to answer that, so theirs goes up too, and pretty soon you’ve got three or four camps burned out over nothing more than someone being awake too long and too sure they were wronged.”

We drive past the Church of Enlightenment, a low, ramshackle compound stitched together from scrap wood, tarpaulin and hay bales. A skeletal wooden tower rises from the centre. “It should be called the Church of Fentanyl,” Jimi says wearily. It’s now an open-air market for hard drugs and Jimi doesn’t want to stop. We continue driving past the imaginary border where I had assumed Slab City ends. There is plastic everywhere, oceans of it, dumped because there is no municipal system to pick it up. We pass the shell of a huge mobile home, and Jimi tells me someone died there – an accidental overdose a few months ago. Nearby, a woman stands too close to a burning oil drum, flames licking.

I mention the phrase people always reach for – “the last free place in America” – and Jimi shakes his head. He says he’s tired of it, so I ask why he stays. Jimi shrugs. “I do still like it here,” he says. “I’ve found a rhythm.” Then he adds: “And where the hell else would I go?”

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THE WEEK CROSSWORD 1503

Two Connell Guides and three Week-branded items will be given to the sender of the first correct solution to the crossword and the clue of the week opened on Monday 23 February. Send it to The Week Crossword 1503, 121-141 Westbourne Terrace, London W2 6JR, or email the completed grid/listed solutions to crossword@theweek.co.uk. By **Tim Moorey** (timmoorey.com)



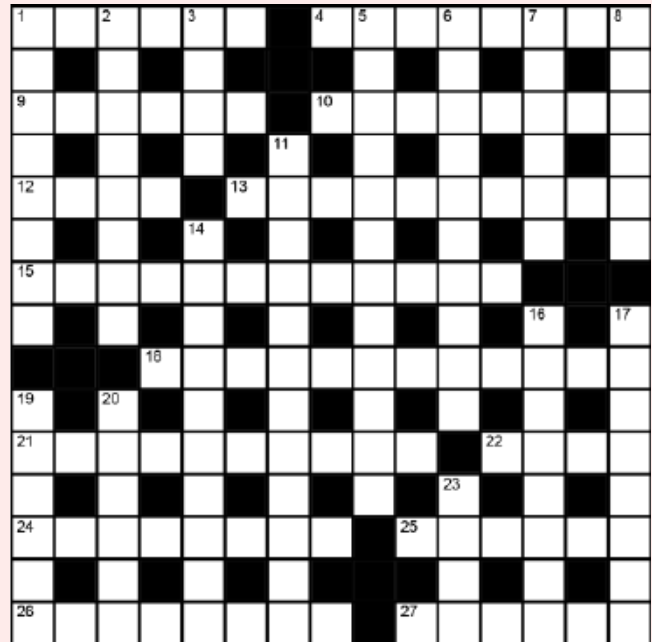
This week's winner will receive Week-branded items, as well as two Connell Guides (connellguides.com).

ACROSS

- 1 Where you focus on say, Turner (6)
- 4 One month alongside gallery undivided into cells (8)
- 9 Second hour in eastern holy place (6)
- 10 Discontinue backing for terror (8)
- 12 Old schoolma'am is hopeless, giving up Latin (4)
- 13 Iran's wrong to cut temporary accommodation for temporary people (10)
- 15 Mouthpieces for cycle accessory business? (12)
- 18 Telling-off for wearing casual clothes? (8-4)
- 21 US port is inclined to follow eccentric owner (3,7)
- 22 Story encapsulating fine sentence (4)
- 24 Outsider in photographic competition? (4,4)
- 25 Starter of antipasti with pecan nuts (6)
- 26 Careless chums going over front of car (8)
- 27 Son quits game (6)

DOWN

- 1 Growth increased under previous president (4-4)
- 2 Twisters giving rent troubles (8)
- 3 Sister mentioned no other person (4)
- 5 Veg to celebrate a leap year? (6,6)
- 6 Labour agree flips making mockery (10)
- 7 Articles about spirit causing complaint (6)
- 8 Still no good missing Anglican church service (4,2)
- 11 Post Office in superstore abroad? That's absurd (12)
- 14 Mistake in poor diets made someone very scared (10)
- 16 Put up with some venom in a testimony (8)
- 17 Whole numbers of irregular regiments losing heart (8)
- 19 Right away bugs in joints (6)
- 20 What fish was called below river in the country (6)
- 23 Empty pub close to failure (4)



Name _____

Address _____

Tel no _____

Clue of the week answer: _____

Clue of the week: Seaside resort overlooking the Isle of Dogs (6, first letter C) *Robert Price, The Sunday Times*

Solution to Crossword 1501

ACROSS: 7 Lone wolf 9 Confab 10 Daze 11 The marines 12 Utopia 14 Turn over 15 Ballet dancers 17 Confetti 19 Nantes 21 Charlatsans 22 Brrr 23 Shmuck 24 Sack race

DOWN: 1 Bogart 2 Pepe 3 Boat race 4 Eclair 5 Antipodean 6 Careless 8 Fleet Admirals 13 Piliiferous 15 Brouhaha 16 Nonesuch 18 Thanks 20 Enrico 22 Bard

Clue of the week: Two and six in old money (6,2,5)

Solution: PIECES OF EIGHT

1501's winners are **Holly, Mel and Sarah O'Brien** from **Glossop**

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Sudoku 1,045 (difficult)

Fill in all the squares so that each row, column and each of the 3x3 squares contains all the digits from 1 to 9

Solution to Sudoku 1,044

6	7	2	3	9	8	1	5	4
9	4	5	2	1	6	7	3	8
3	1	8	5	4	7	9	6	2
4	8	9	1	2	5	3	7	6
7	5	3	6	8	4	2	9	1
1	2	6	9	7	3	4	8	5
5	9	1	7	6	2	8	4	3
8	6	7	4	3	1	5	2	9
2	3	4	8	5	9	6	1	7

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